

Wirsching's 2003 Conjectures on Positive Predecessor Density: Conjectures 1 and 3 Proved

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Abstract

Wirsching (2003) reduces uniform positive predecessor density for the $3n + 1$ map to a chain of five conditions, organized into three conjectures. We prove two of them. Conjecture 1 concerns his path-counting generators: in the convolution carrying them to his Elka functions the partition weights grow subexponentially while the binomial ratio decays geometrically, so a window of width $O(\sqrt{\ell})$ dominates and its radius fits inside the hypothesis. Conjecture 3 concerns the asymptotics near 0 of an invariant density φ , a base-3 analogue of the Fabius density, against an explicit φ_0 due to Berg and Krüppel. The exact log-Laplace transform of φ splits into a smooth part, a log 3-periodic correction H , and a doubly exponentially small remainder. Berg and Krüppel gave that correction as an infinite product in 1998 and did not ask whether it is constant. We give H as a Fourier series with coefficients in closed form in Γ and ζ ; a classical zero-free theorem for ζ shows it is not constant, and we enclose its oscillation rigorously. Wirsching's comparison class fixes one phase of H , and there Conjecture 3 holds with limit $e^{H(0)} = 0.534122\dots$. Off that class the phase sweeps a full period, so the unrestricted asymptotic $\varphi(t) \sim \kappa\varphi_0(t)$ fails. Condition $(\star 4)$ follows, at every window radius, with $\mu = 1/3$: what Wirsching's argument needs is weaker than Conjecture 3 itself, and the same saddlepoint chain settles it directly. With Conjecture 1 the chain reduces to the single condition $(\star 3)$. Conjecture 2 is his route to it and remains open.

1 Introduction

Let T denote the $3n + 1$ map on the positive integers, $T(n) = n/2$ for n even and $T(n) = (3n + 1)/2$ for n odd. Wirsching's monograph [6] develops the predecessor-set machinery this paper descends from, and [1] takes it further, studying the density of predecessor sets through an averaging construction on the 3-adic integers. A family of operators S_ℓ , built from path counts in the predecessor graph, converges in the strong operator topology to a limiting operator whose essential part is a Markov chain on $[0, 1]$. That chain has a unique invariant density φ , a base-3 analogue of the Fabius density, and Wirsching reduces uniform positive predecessor density to a chain of five conditions $(\star 1)$ through $(\star 5)$ about φ and the path counts, organized into three conjectures. None of the three had a published resolution.

Two of them are proved here.

Conjecture 1 asks that a pointwise lower bound on Wirsching's generators, relative to their 3-adic Haar average, transfer to his Elka functions. Theorem 4.3 proves it. In the convolution carrying the generators to the Elka functions the partition weights grow subexponentially while the binomial ratio decays geometrically, so a window of width $O(\sqrt{\ell})$ dominates, and its radius can

be budgeted to sit inside the hypothesis. Together with Wirsching's own two theorems this makes $(\star 3)$ alone sufficient for uniform positive predecessor density, unconditionally (Corollary 4.4).

Conjecture 3 concerns φ near 0, compared against an explicit φ_0 . Wirsching's equation (7.11) defines φ_0 to be Berg and Krüppel's asymptotic solution [3], naming them in the sentence that introduces it, so the identification is his and not a substitution made here. They had produced φ_0 five years earlier, as the asymptotic solution of a truncated version of the functional equation φ satisfies, and gave the periodic correction relating the two as an infinite product without ever evaluating it. The exact log-Laplace transform of φ decomposes as a smooth part, a log 3-periodic correction H , and a doubly exponentially small remainder (Theorem 6.1). We give H as a Fourier series with coefficients in closed form in Γ and ζ (Proposition 6.3). The classical zero-free theorem for ζ on $\operatorname{Re} s = 1$ then shows H is not constant, with no computation, and its oscillation is enclosed rigorously (Proposition 6.5). Wirsching's comparison class fixes a single phase of H ; there Conjecture 3 holds, with limit $e^{H(0)}$ (Theorem 10.1). Away from that class the phase sweeps a full period, so the stronger unrestricted asymptotic $\varphi(t) \sim \kappa \varphi_0(t)$ fails (Theorem 10.2). The function e^H is Berg and Krüppel's own periodic factor for this eigenfunction (Corollary 10.3).

Condition $(\star 4)$ follows, for every window radius, with $\mu = 1/3$ (Theorem 11.1). Wirsching's own route there is to compose $(\star 5) \Rightarrow (\star 4)$ with Conjecture 3, and that works; what his argument actually needs is weaker than Conjecture 3, and Proposition 10.6 settles it directly from the same saddlepoint chain, without the class bookkeeping. His chain is then closed except at $(\star 3)$, and Conjecture 2, the implication $(\star 4) \Rightarrow (\star 3)$, is the only conjectural link left in it.

Conjecture 2 is not proved here and not attacked here. What can be said about it from the outside is in §12.

§2 places the problem against the density and distributional literature. §3 fixes Wirsching's objects and states the chain from the primary source. §4 proves Conjecture 1. §§5 to 10 prove Conjecture 3, through the periodic correction, a uniform saddlepoint approximation, an envelope estimate, and the identification with Berg and Krüppel's asymptotic. §11 composes the chain.

2 Related work

The predecessor-density question is older than Wirsching's formulation of it. Crandall raised the counting of $3n+1$ predecessors as a quantitative problem [8], and Sander improved his lower bound on the number of descending integers below a given x [9]. Krasikov then turned the question into a system of difference inequalities on the counting functions [12]. Applegate and Lagarias then produced density exponents by two independent routes: a tree-search method following Crandall [13], and, separately, a linear-programming solution of Krasikov's system [14]. Krasikov and Lagarias later pushed the same inequalities further, obtaining for each fixed $a \not\equiv 0 \pmod 3$, and for x large depending on a , at least $x^{0.84}$ integers below x with a in their forward orbit [16]. That is the current state of the art for the exponent. It is a sublinear count with an a -dependent threshold, so it is weaker in both respects than the uniform positive density, of order x/a , that Wirsching's chain targets.

Wirsching's own contribution to this line begins with an improved predecessor-set estimate [15], continues through the combinatorial structure of those sets [17], the monograph [6] and the urn model [4], and produces in 2003 the five-condition chain studied here [1].

Between the monograph and the chain he tried an analytic route. Wirsching (2001) links an integral operator to the limiting behaviour of transitions between counting functions attached to predecessor sets, reduces the resulting integral equation to a linear retarded functional differential equation, and reports that the normalized averages of the Elka functions diverge pointwise to $+\infty$.

He states there that what the limiting behaviour of the transition means for the combinatorial quantities themselves was not known [7, §§1,5]. The invariant density φ that the chain's last condition concerns belongs to a function class with its own literature: Berg and Krüppel supplied the asymptotic used here [3], and Rvachev's survey covers the functional-differential family these densities sit in, which Wirsching's 2001 concluding remarks point at and leave open [18, 7]. Operators attached to the Collatz map have also been studied for their own dynamics, where the behaviour is opposite: Béhani, building on earlier work, shows an associated operator on weighted Bergman spaces is hypercyclic and, under conditions, chaotic [19], while the averaging operator W_3 used below contracts each affine hyperplane of fixed mass and fixes exactly one function of unit mass supported in $[0, 1]$.

A second line of work models $3n+1$ dynamics probabilistically, and it is where $(\star 3)$'s residue-level content lives. Borovkov and Pfeifer estimated the Syracuse problem through a probabilistic model [20], Kontorovich and Sinai gave a structure theorem for the maps in question [21], and Kontorovich and Lagarias set the stochastic models for $3x+1$ and $5x+1$ side by side [22]. Sinai studied the inverse-path ensemble and its random-walk statistics [23], and proved weak convergence of the residues induced modulo 3^n by independent geometric variables to the uniform measure, noting that the strengthened version in which individual probabilities converge is false [24]. Volkov's randomly labelled binary tree for $5x+1$ carries direction-dependent edge laws [25], and Tao's Syracuse random variable [5] is the residue law $(\star 3)$ is a statement about: it approaches uniformity at fine scales while failing to be uniformly distributed on $\mathbb{Z}/3^n\mathbb{Z}$.

Current work runs in several directions. Computation has verified the conjecture below 2^{71} [26]. On the exponent, $x^{0.84}$ [16] remains the published record; a recent preprint returns to the counting problem by a different route and obtains $x^{0.3227}$, describing 0.84 as the historical record [10]. A 2026 preprint of Mazur raises the exponent to $x^{0.90}$ by an exact feasible point for the level-18 Krasikov–Lagarias linear program together with an adaptive elimination of advanced terms, with the whole theorem formalized in Lean and its two native-computation steps replayed by independent exact verifiers [11]. It is unrefereed, and it declares substantial generative-AI involvement in the mathematics; the formalization is what carries it. None of this line reaches what Wirsching's chain targets: these are sublinear counts with an a -dependent threshold, where the chain aims at a density of order x/a uniform in a . Other recent work addresses the finer structure of trajectories, a different question again [27].

The third conjecture sits in a second literature, on the equation φ satisfies rather than on the $3n+1$ map. That equation is a two-scale difference equation with dilation parameter 3, in Berg and Krüppel's family [3], and φ is a translate of Rvachev's atomic function h_3 [18]. Kato and McLeod's study of $y'(x) = ay(\lambda x) + by(x)$ [30] is the analytic ancestor, and Derfel surveys the family [31]. Wirsching noticed the connection to Rvachev's functions himself and left it to future work [7].

Solutions of such equations carry log-periodic fluctuations in their asymptotics. The phenomenon goes back to de Bruijn on Mahler's partition problem [28] and to Erdős and Richmond [29], and the technique of extracting the fluctuation's Fourier coefficients as residues of a Dirichlet series is developed for radix-rational sequences by Dumas [33] and for q -regular sequences by Heuberger and Krenn [34]. That work treats summatory functions of sequences. Corollary 10.3 applies the same mechanism to an eigenfunction of the difference equation itself, which is where the Γ and ζ coefficients of Proposition 6.3 come from, and with them the non-constancy of H .

Wirsching's three conjectures themselves have gone unworked. The 2003 paper is cited sparsely, in bibliographies of the problem and in adjacent work, and no published follow-up takes up any of the three. For the second, what this paper gives is an account of how far the machinery natural to it reaches, and where the argument developed here stops.

3 Wirsching's chain, from the primary source

Wirsching's central combinatorial objects are the “Elka” functions $e_\ell(k, a) := |E_{\ell, k}(a)|$, on domain $\mathbb{N}_0 \times \mathbb{Z}_3^\times$ [1, §1–2], where $E_{\ell, k}(a)$ is the set of paths $b \xrightarrow{T} \dots \xrightarrow{T} a$ in the Collatz graph with $T = T_0$ exactly k times and $T = T_1$ exactly ℓ times (T_0, T_1 the two branches of the accelerated $3n+1$ map). Their normalized generators $\tilde{g}_\ell$ (defined below) live on the continuous state space $\mathbb{X} = \mathbb{I}_3 \times \mathbb{Z}_3^\times$: the $\mathbb{Z}_3^\times$ factor carries the 3-adic variable habitat of the Syracuse measure, while the $\mathbb{I}_3 \cong \{0, 1, 2\}^\mathbb{N}$ factor carries the normalized step count $k/3^\ell$, converging to a density φ .

The compactly supported *generators* $g_\ell(k, a)$ are defined by the recursion [1, §2, eq. (2.1)]

$$g_{\ell+1}(k, a) = \sum_{0 \leq j < 2 \cdot 3^\ell} g_\ell(k - j, \frac{2^{j+1}a-1}{3}), \quad g_0(k, a) = \mathbf{1}[k = 0] \mathbf{1}[a \in \mathbb{Z}_3], \quad (1)$$

linked to the Elka functions by $e_\ell = p_\ell * g_\ell$, where $p_\ell(m)$ counts the ways to pay m with coins $c_0 = 1$, $c_j = 2 \cdot 3^{j-1}$ ($j \geq 1$) [1, §2]. The class A_δ consists of the integer sequences (k_ℓ) with $|\ell - k_\ell| \leq \delta\sqrt{\ell}$ for every ℓ [1, eq. (1.5)]; $\tilde{A}_\delta$ is the analogous class of sequences $(x_\ell) \in \mathbb{I}_3^\mathbb{N}$, those with $|\lfloor 3^\ell x_\ell \rfloor - \ell| \leq \delta\sqrt{\ell}$ [1, eq. (3.2)], used in conditions $(\star 4)$ and $(\star 5)$ below.

Two densities remain. φ satisfies the untruncated equation $\lambda\varphi'(t) = a(\varphi(at) - \varphi(at - a + 1))$ for $a = 3$, $\lambda = 2/3$ [1, eq. (7.9)]; the base parameter a of that equation and of Berg and Krüppel's is unrelated to the 3-adic unit a everywhere else in this paper.

φ_0 is Berg and Krüppel's explicit asymptotic [3, Proposition 9.1, eq. (9.6)] for a particular solution of the truncated equation $\lambda g'(t) = ag(at)$, a closed form which, at $a = 3$ and $\lambda = 2/3$, reads

$$\ln \varphi_0(t) = \varepsilon \ln(2\beta) - \frac{1}{2} \ln(2\pi) + \gamma \ln t + \delta_{\text{BK}} \ln(-\ln t) - \beta \ln^2\left(\frac{t}{-\ln t}\right), \quad (2)$$

with $\alpha = \frac{1}{2} - \log_3 2$, $\beta = 1/(2 \ln 3)$, $\delta_{\text{BK}} = \frac{1}{2} + \alpha - 2\beta \ln(2\beta)$, $\gamma = -2\beta - \delta_{\text{BK}} - \frac{1}{2}$ and $\varepsilon = \frac{1}{2} + \alpha - \beta \ln(2\beta)$. Proposition 9.1 states the last three; α and β come from [3, eq. (9.4)], and the specialization $\lambda = (a-1)/a$ that fixes α for this equation sits between Propositions 9.2 and 9.3 [3, p. 180], where the printed line carries a in place of $\ln a$; the value used here is the one (9.4) forces. Their δ is written δ_{BK} throughout, since δ is the window radius everywhere else here.

Berg and Krüppel expect only that φ/φ_0 stays bounded and bounded away from zero, weaker than convergence [3, §9], and Wirsching restates the truncated equation and this asymptotic at [1, eq. (7.10)–(7.11)]; φ_0 is used in Conjecture 3 below in place of φ itself, which has no known closed form.

Proposition 3.1 (Base-3 Fabius density). *φ is the density of $X = \sum_{j \geq 1} 2U_j \cdot 3^{-j}$, U_j i.i.d. uniform on $[0, 1]$ (an identification not in the source), the base-3 analogue of the Fabius density [2] (the base-2 case satisfies $h'(x) = 4h(2x)$ on $[0, 1/2]$; here $\varphi'(x) = (9/2)\varphi(3x)$ on $[0, 2/3]$ by [1, eq. (7.7)], the same shape with base 3 in place of base 2: coefficient $4 = 2^2/(2-1)$ becomes $9/2 = 3^2/(3-1)$, support cutoff $1/2 = (2-1)/2$ becomes $2/3 = (3-1)/3$). Extend every function on $[0, 1]$ by zero to $\mathbb{R}$ before applying $W_3 f(x) := \frac{3}{2} \int_{3x-2}^{3x} f(t) dt$. Among the functions f with $\text{supp } f \subset [0, 1]$ and $\int_0^1 f = 1$, φ is the unique fixed point of W_3 , and it is C^∞ , piecewise polynomial away from the standard Cantor set [1, Corollary 7]. For $f_0 \in L^1([0, 1])$ with $\int_0^1 f_0 = 1$, the iterates $f_{n+1} := W_3 f_n$ converge geometrically, $\|f_n - \varphi\|_1 \leq 2^{-n+1} \|f_1 - f_0\|_1$ [1, Corollary 8].*

Proof. Only the first claim needs an argument; the rest is quoted. Write $X = \sum_{j \geq 1} 2U_j 3^{-j}$ and $X' = \sum_{j \geq 1} 2U_{j+1} 3^{-j}$, so $X = (2U_1 + X')/3$ with $X' \stackrel{d}{=} X$ independent of U_1 . Here $2U_1/3$ is uniform

on $[0, 2/3]$ and independent of $X'/3$, so the sum of the two is absolutely continuous. Write f for its density. Conditioning on U_1 and differentiating,

$$f(x) = \frac{d}{dx} \mathbb{E}_U[F_X(3x - 2U)] = 3 \int_0^1 f(3x - 2u) du = \frac{3}{2} \int_{3x-2}^{3x} f(t) dt = W_3 f(x),$$

the substitution $t = 3x - 2u$ giving $du = -dt/2$. Each summand lies in $[0, 2 \cdot 3^{-j}]$, so $X \in [0, 2 \sum_{j \geq 1} 3^{-j}] = [0, 1]$ and $\text{supp } f \subset [0, 1]$; also $f \in L^1$ with $\int_0^1 f = 1$. So f is a fixed point of W_3 meeting the two side conditions, and φ is the only one [1, Corollary 7]. Hence $f = \varphi$. $\square$

Wirsching's paper reduces uniform positive predecessor density (that the sets of predecessors of a have lower asymptotic density bounded below by c/a , for a single constant $c > 0$ uniform over admissible targets a) to a chain of five conditions [1, Definition 1, §§1–7]:

Theorem 1 (proved in [1])	(★1) $\Rightarrow$ Positive Density
Conjecture 1	(★2) $\Rightarrow$ (★1)
Theorem 2 (proved in [1])	(★3) $\Rightarrow$ (★2)
Conjecture 2	(★4) $\Rightarrow$ (★3)
Conjecture 3	(★5); (★5) $\Rightarrow$ (★4) proved in [1, §7]

That is the chain as the source leaves it. Its status after §4 and §10 is the subject of §11: (★5) and (★4) are established outright, every implication from (★3) downward is a theorem, and Conjecture 2 is the one implication still conjectural. Here (★1) is a $\liminf$ lower bound on Wirsching's Elka functions relative to their Haar average, uniform over sequences (k_ℓ) with $|\ell - k_\ell| \leq \delta\sqrt{\ell}$; (★2) is the same statement for his generators $g_\ell(k, a)$; (★3) upgrades the $\liminf$ over ℓ to a bound holding for every $\ell \geq \ell_0$; and (★4) asserts that there is a constant $\mu > 0$ with

$$\liminf_{\ell} \frac{(W_3^\ell \chi_1)(x_\ell)}{(W_3^\ell \chi_0)(x_\ell)} \geq \mu, \quad \text{uniformly for } (x_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_\delta,$$

with $\chi_0 = \mathbf{1}_{[0, 2/3]}$, $\chi_1 = \mathbf{1}_{[1/3, 1]}$, and W_3 the averaging operator of Proposition 3.1.

First, (★4) is a statement purely about the one-dimensional operator W_3 . It never mentions Wirsching's generators and never mentions the 3-adic unit a , so it supplies no residue-level information, which is what (★3) is a statement about. The source offers two bridges: the averaged-generator identity $\lim_{\ell} \int_{\mathbb{Z}_3^\times} \tilde{g}_\ell(x, a) da = \varphi(x)$ for fixed $x \in \mathbb{I}_3$ [1, §6], and Wirsching's Theorem 3 [1, §5], strong convergence $S_\ell \rightarrow S_\infty$ for every $f \in C(\mathbb{X})$, of the transition operators $S_\ell : C(\mathbb{X}) \rightarrow C(\mathbb{X})$ defined by $\tilde{g}_\ell = S_\ell(\tilde{g}_{\ell-1})$ [1, §4], uniform on bounded equicontinuous families. Neither bridge is uniform in growing resolution, so neither closes the gap between (★4) and (★3).

Second, (★3) and (★2) are the same inequality. Writing $\tilde{g}_\ell(x, a) = \gamma_\ell g_\ell(\lfloor 3^\ell x \rfloor, a)$ for a constant γ_ℓ not depending on a , the constant cancels from both sides of the ratio each condition bounds; what Wirsching's Theorem 2 adds is a change of quantifier, from a $\liminf$ in ℓ to a bound holding at every $\ell \geq \ell_0$.

Third, Theorem 1's conclusion, uniform positive predecessor density, is about $a \in \mathbb{N}$, non-cyclic, $a \not\equiv 0 \pmod{3}$; its hypothesis (★1), like (★2) and (★3), is stated over $\mathbb{Z}_3^\times$.

4 Wirsching's Conjecture 1

Throughout this section, fix $a \in \mathbb{Z}_3^\times$ and write $\bar{g}_\ell(k) := \int_{\mathbb{Z}_3^\times} g_\ell(k, b) db$ and $\bar{e}_\ell(k) := \int_{\mathbb{Z}_3^\times} e_\ell(k, b) db$ for the 3-adic averages. Put $c_0 = 1$ and $c_j = 2 \cdot 3^{j-1}$ for $j \geq 1$. Wirsching's convolution formulas

$$e_\ell(k, a) = \sum_{j=0}^k p_\ell(k-j) g_\ell(j, a), \quad \bar{e}_\ell = p_\ell * \bar{g}_\ell \quad (3)$$

hold at each fixed a and on the averages respectively [1, eq. (2.3), (2.4)], with $p_\ell(m)$ the number of partitions of m into the parts $c_0, \dots, c_\ell$ with repetition. Both g_ℓ and p_ℓ are non-negative.

Neither $(\star 2)$ nor $(\star 1)$ says anything about uniformity in a , so nothing below assumes any; a stays fixed and every constant is allowed to depend on it.

Lemma 4.1 (Window form of the hypothesis). *Suppose $(\star 2)$ holds with radius δ_1 and constant μ_1 . Then for every $\varepsilon > 0$ there is ℓ_0 such that for every $\ell \geq \ell_0$ and every integer j with $|j - \ell| \leq \delta_1 \sqrt{\ell}$,*

$$g_\ell(j, a) \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon) \bar{g}_\ell(j).$$

Proof. The hypothesis is a $\liminf$ holding uniformly for sequences $(k_\ell) \in A_{\delta_1}$, so the ℓ_0 it supplies does not depend on the sequence: there is ℓ_0 with $g_\ell(k_\ell, a) \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon) \bar{g}_\ell(k_\ell)$ for every $\ell \geq \ell_0$ and every $(k_\ell) \in A_{\delta_1}$. Given ℓ and j as in the statement, set $k_m := m$ for $m \neq \ell$ and $k_\ell := j$. Then $|m - k_m| = 0 \leq \delta_1 \sqrt{m}$ for $m \neq \ell$ and $|\ell - k_\ell| \leq \delta_1 \sqrt{\ell}$, so $(k_m) \in A_{\delta_1}$. Reading the bound for this sequence at index ℓ gives the claim. $\square$

A single sequence controls one index per level. The lemma is what turns that into control of the whole window at one level, which is what the convolution needs, and it is the only place the “uniformly for sequences” wording is load bearing.

Lemma 4.2 (Tail of the convolution). *Fix $\delta > 0$. There are $\rho \in (0, 1)$ and $A > 0$, depending only on δ , such that for every $\tau > 0$ and all large ℓ ,*

$$\frac{1}{\bar{e}_\ell(k)} \sum_{m \geq \tau \sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) \bar{g}_\ell(k-m) \leq \frac{A}{1-\rho} \rho^{\tau \sqrt{\ell}} \quad \text{uniformly for } |k - \ell| \leq \delta \sqrt{\ell}.$$

In particular the left side is $O(e^{-c\sqrt{\ell}})$ with $c = \tau \log(1/\rho) > 0$.

Proof. Cancelling $\prod_{j=0}^\ell (1 - z^{c_j})$ against its inverse in

$$Q_\ell(z) := \sum_{k \geq 0} q_\ell(k) z^k = \prod_{j=0}^\ell \frac{1 - z^{c_j}}{1 - z}, \quad P_\ell(z) := \sum_{m \geq 0} p_\ell(m) z^m = \prod_{j=0}^\ell (1 - z^{c_j})^{-1}$$

gives $P_\ell(z) Q_\ell(z) = (1 - z)^{-\ell-1}$, so by (3)

$$\bar{e}_\ell(k) = \frac{1}{2 \cdot 3^{\ell-1}} \binom{k + \ell}{\ell}, \quad (4)$$

where $q_\ell(k) = 2 \cdot 3^{\ell-1} \bar{g}_\ell(k)$ counts the distributions of k indistinguishable balls into urns $U_0, \dots, U_\ell$ of capacities c_j [1, §2], the occupancy range $0, \dots, c_j - 1$ being what the support bound $\sum_j (c_j - 1) = 3^\ell - \ell - 1$ forces.

Since $p_\ell(0) = 1$ and every term is non-negative, $\bar{g}_\ell(j) \leq \bar{e}_\ell(j)$ for every j , so by (4)

$$\frac{\bar{g}_\ell(k-m)}{\bar{e}_\ell(k)} \leq \frac{\binom{k-m+\ell}{\ell}}{\binom{k+\ell}{\ell}} = \prod_{i=1}^m \frac{k-i+1}{k+\ell-i+1} \leq \left(\frac{k}{k+\ell}\right)^m.$$

In the window $k \leq \ell + \delta\sqrt{\ell}$, so $k/(k+\ell) \leq (\ell + \delta\sqrt{\ell})/(2\ell + \delta\sqrt{\ell}) \rightarrow \frac{1}{2}$ and the ratio is at most $\rho_0 := 3/5$ for all large ℓ , uniformly in k . Fix $\rho := 7/10$. The partition count obeys

$$p_\ell(m) \leq \exp(C \log^2(m+2)) : \quad (5)$$

$p_\ell(0) = 1$, and for $m \geq 1$ only the parts $c_j \leq m$ contribute, at most $\log_3(m/2) + 2$ of them, each with multiplicity at most m , so $p_\ell(m) \leq (m+1)^{\log_3(m/2)+2}$. The bound is uniform in ℓ . Hence $A := \sup_{m \geq 0} \exp(C \log^2(m+2))(\rho_0/\rho)^m$ is finite, being the supremum of a subexponentially growing factor against a geometric one with ratio $6/7 < 1$, and

$$\sum_{m \geq \tau\sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) \frac{\bar{g}_\ell(k-m)}{\bar{e}_\ell(k)} \leq \sum_{m \geq \tau\sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) \rho_0^m \leq A \sum_{m \geq \tau\sqrt{\ell}} \rho^m = \frac{A}{1-\rho} \rho^{\lceil \tau\sqrt{\ell} \rceil}. \quad \square$$

Theorem 4.3 (Wirsching's Conjecture 1). *In the notation of §3, condition $(\star 2)$, with window radius δ_1 (Wirsching's own naming, [1, §2]), implies condition $(\star 1)$ with some possibly smaller window radius $\delta < \delta_1$.*

Proof. Choose $\tau > 0$ and $\delta > 0$ with $\delta + \tau < \delta_1$, and let $\varepsilon > 0$. Take ℓ_0 from Lemma 4.1 for that ε . Let $|k - \ell| \leq \delta\sqrt{\ell}$ with $\ell \geq \ell_0$ large enough for Lemma 4.2. For $m < \tau\sqrt{\ell}$ the index $j = k - m$ satisfies $|j - \ell| \leq (\delta + \tau)\sqrt{\ell} < \delta_1\sqrt{\ell}$, so Lemma 4.1 applies at every such j at once. Dropping the non-negative terms with $m \geq \tau\sqrt{\ell}$ from (3) and then restoring them inside the average,

$$\begin{aligned} e_\ell(k, a) &\geq \sum_{m < \tau\sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) g_\ell(k-m, a) \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon) \sum_{m < \tau\sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) \bar{g}_\ell(k-m) \\ &= (\mu_1 - \varepsilon) \left(\bar{e}_\ell(k) - \sum_{m \geq \tau\sqrt{\ell}} p_\ell(m) \bar{g}_\ell(k-m) \right) \geq (\mu_1 - \varepsilon)(1 - \eta_\ell) \bar{e}_\ell(k), \end{aligned}$$

with $\eta_\ell = O(e^{-c\sqrt{\ell}})$ by Lemma 4.2, uniformly over the window and independent of k . So for every sequence $(k_\ell) \in A_\delta$, $\liminf_\ell e_\ell(k_\ell, a)/\bar{e}_\ell(k_\ell) \geq \mu_1 - \varepsilon$, uniformly over such sequences because ℓ_0 and η_ℓ are. Letting $\varepsilon \downarrow 0$ gives $(\star 1)$ at radius δ with constant μ_1 , and $(\star 1)$ asks only for some positive constant. $\square$

Corollary 4.4. *Condition $(\star 3)$ implies uniform positive predecessor density on the non-cyclic integers $a \not\equiv 0 \pmod{3}$.*

Proof. Wirsching's Theorem 2 takes $(\star 3)$ to $(\star 2)$ [1, §2], Theorem 4.3 takes $(\star 2)$ to $(\star 1)$, and his Theorem 1 takes $(\star 1)$ to the conclusion [1, §1]. Both of his theorems quantify their window radius and constant existentially, so the possibly smaller radius produced by Theorem 4.3 is admissible in Theorem 1 as it stands. $\square$

Before this the chain from $(\star 3)$ downward passed through Conjecture 1. It no longer does, and $(\star 4) \Rightarrow (\star 3)$ is the only conjectural link left below $(\star 4)$.

Remark 4.5 (Relation to the source). Wirsching records the partition-counting identity $\prod_{j=0}^{\ell} (1 - z^{c_j})^{-1} = \sum_m p_{\ell}(m) z^m$ [1, §2, eq. (2.2)] and the closed form for $\bar{e}_{\ell}(k)$ used above [1, §1, eq. (1.4)], and describes, without a generating function, the urn count $q_{\ell}(k) = 2 \cdot 3^{\ell-1} \bar{g}_{\ell}(k)$, crediting the combinatorial identification to [4] [1, §2]; the generator apparatus itself is developed in [6, Ch. IV, p. 103 and Thm. IV.1.14], the pinpoints Wirsching himself gives for it [1, §2]; the generating function $\sum_k q_{\ell}(k) z^k = \prod_{j=0}^{\ell} (1 - z^{c_j}) / (1 - z)$ used above does not appear there. Wirsching states the implication itself as Conjecture 1 [1, §§1–2]. The cancellation $P_{\ell}(z)Q_{\ell}(z) = (1 - z)^{-\ell-1}$ is what makes $\bar{e}_{\ell}(k)$ binomial.

The second conjecture is untouched by this. Its antecedent ($\star 4$) comes from Conjecture 3, an asymptotic assertion on $\varphi(z_{\ell})/\varphi_0(z_{\ell})$ along the central-limit window $|\ell - k_{\ell}| \leq \delta_5 \sqrt{\ell}$, which §§5 to 10 prove and §11 composes with the present section.

5 The invariant density and its Laplace transform

Proposition 3.1 identifies φ as the density of $X = \sum_{j \geq 1} 2 \cdot 3^{-j} U_j$ with U_j i.i.d. uniform on $[0, 1]$, the unique fixed point of W_3 of unit mass supported in $[0, 1]$. At dilation parameter $a = 3$ and $\lambda = 2/3$ it is an instance of Berg and Krüppel’s family $\lambda \psi'(t) = a(\psi(at) - \psi(at - 2))$, and a translate of Rvachev’s atomic function h_3 [18]. Three further facts are used throughout below.

The reflection $x \mapsto 1 - x$, which fixes the convention in [1, Cor. 7], is vacuous here: $\varphi(x) = \varphi(1 - x)$ identically, since X and $1 - X = \sum_{j \geq 1} \frac{2}{3^j} (1 - U_j)$ are equidistributed, since $1 - U_j \sim U_j$ independently for every j and $\sum_{j \geq 1} 2 \cdot 3^{-j} = 1$ are equidistributed. It is continuous, by Lemma 7.3 below. And it is constant, equal to $3/2$, on the middle third $[1/3, 2/3]$: there $3x - 2 \leq 0 \leq 1 \leq 3x$, so $\text{supp } \varphi \subset [0, 1]$ collapses the integral in $W_3 \varphi = \varphi$ to $\int_0^1 \varphi = 1$.

For $s > 0$ write

$$K(s) = \log \mathbb{E}[e^{-sX}] = \sum_{j \geq 1} g\left(\frac{2s}{3^j}\right), \quad g(b) = \log \frac{1 - e^{-b}}{b}.$$

The branch of g is the one analytic on $\{\text{Re } w > 0\}$ and real on $(0, \infty)$; since $(1 - e^{-w})/w$ is analytic and non-vanishing there (its zeros lie on $2\pi i\mathbb{Z} \setminus \{0\}$, and $w = 0$ is a removable singularity with value 1), and the half-plane is simply connected, g exists and is unique. Differentiating termwise, justified because $g(w) = -w/2 + O(w^2)$ as $w \rightarrow 0$ so the tail of the series is normally convergent together with every derivative,

$$t(s) := -K'(s), \quad V(s) := s^2 K''(s) > 0,$$

the second an exact positivity, $K''(s)$ being the variance of X under its exponential tilt by e^{-sX} . Since $t'(s) = -K''(s) < 0$, t is strictly decreasing on $(0, \infty)$; at the endpoints, $t(0^+) = \mathbb{E}[X] = \sum_{j \geq 1} 2 \cdot 3^{-j} \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{2}$, and $t(s) \rightarrow 0$ as $s \rightarrow \infty$ because the exponential tilt concentrates on $\text{ess inf } X = 0$ (each factor e^{-sX} suppresses any mass away from 0 as $s \rightarrow \infty$, and $X \geq 0$ a.s.). So $t(s)$ decreases strictly from $1/2$ to 0, and studying $\varphi(t(s))$ as $s \rightarrow \infty$ is the same as studying $\varphi(t)$ as $t \rightarrow 0^+$.

The comparison function φ_0 is (2), Berg and Krüppel’s asymptotic solution of the truncated equation $\lambda \psi'(t) = a \psi(at)$ by Laplace transform and saddlepoint analysis, with the constants $\alpha, \beta, \gamma, \delta_{\text{BK}}, \varepsilon$ fixed there. Their dilation parameter a is reused in §6 for this paper’s own, unrelated linear coefficient of Q ; the two never appear in the same formula except in §9, where the collision is flagged at the point it matters. Write $\varphi_{0, \text{bare}}$ for (2) without the leading constant $(2\beta)^{\varepsilon}/\sqrt{2\pi}$.

6 The periodic correction

Set $c = \log 3$ and write $w = \log s$, $L(w) = K(e^w)$. Substituting into the defining series and splitting off the $j = 1$ term against the rest reproduces the recurrence

$$L(w + c) - L(w) = \log(1 - e^{-2e^w}) - w - \log 2. \quad (6)$$

Let

$$Q(w) = -\frac{w^2}{2c} + \left(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log 2}{c}\right)w,$$

chosen so that $Q(w + c) - Q(w) = -w - \log 2$, matching (6)'s non-periodic terms exactly. Write $a := \frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log 2}{c}$ for Q 's linear coefficient, used again from Section 8 onward.

Theorem 6.1. *Define*

$$H(w) := L(w) - Q(w) + \sum_{k \geq 0} \log(1 - e^{-2 \cdot 3^k e^w}). \quad (7)$$

Then H is exactly c -periodic, $H(w + c) = H(w)$ for every $w \in \mathbb{R}$, and

$$L(w) = Q(w) + H(w) + \Delta(w), \quad \Delta(w) = -\sum_{k \geq 0} \log(1 - e^{-2 \cdot 3^k e^w}),$$

with $\Delta^{(j)}(w) = O_j(e^{jw-2e^w})$ for every $j \geq 0$: doubly exponentially small, together with all its derivatives, as $w \rightarrow +\infty$.

Proof. Write $d(w) = \log(1 - e^{-2e^w})$, so (6) reads $L(w + c) - L(w) = d(w) - w - \log 2$. Directly from the definition of Q (expand $(w + c)^2 = w^2 + 2wc + c^2$ and collect terms), $Q(w + c) - Q(w) = -w - \log 2$ as well, so the two non-periodic parts cancel exactly:

$$(L - Q)(w + c) - (L - Q)(w) = [d(w) - w - \log 2] - [-w - \log 2] = d(w).$$

The series in (7) telescopes this exactly: with $D(w) := (L - Q)(w)$,

$$D(w) + \sum_{k \geq 0} d(w + kc) = D(w + c) - d(w) + \sum_{k \geq 0} d(w + kc) = D(w + c) + \sum_{k \geq 0} d(w + (k + 1)c),$$

so the right side of (7) is invariant under $w \mapsto w + c$, that is, H is c -periodic. Convergence of the series and its termwise differentiability, together with the stated bound on $\Delta^{(j)}$, follow from $d(w) = O(e^{-2e^w})$ and the corresponding bounds on its derivatives, since $2 \cdot 3^k e^w$ grows like 3^k for $k \geq 0$: the terms $d(w + kc)$ decay doubly exponentially in k , hence faster than any fixed geometric rate, which gives uniform, dominated convergence of the series and its derivatives for w in any half-line bounded away from $-\infty$. $\square$

Given Q , H is uniquely determined by the requirement that $L - Q - H$ be $o(1)$ as $w \rightarrow \infty$: any two periodic functions differing from $L - Q$ by an $o(1)$ term as $w \rightarrow \infty$ must be equal, being periodic functions that agree in the limit along every residue class of w modulo c .

Remark 6.2. Berg and Krüppel's own Proposition 9.3, specialized to their dilation parameter 3 and their $b = 3/2$ (exactly this eigenfunction; their α , kept as a symbol here, is exactly Section 5's imported α , which Proposition 9.1 below identifies with this paper's own a), gives the equivalent identity $\exp(H(w)) = 3^{\frac{1}{2}t^2 - \alpha t} \prod_{k \geq 0} \frac{1 - e^{-3^{t-k}/b}}{3^{t-k}/b} \prod_{i \geq 1} (1 - e^{-3^{t+i}/b})$, $t = w/c$, as an infinite product,

in their proof of that proposition. This is $e^{-Q}e^Le^{-\Delta}$ term for term: writing $s = e^w = 3^t$, $3^{t-k}/b = 2s/3^{k+1}$, so reindexing $j := k + 1 \geq 1$ turns the first product into $\prod_{j \geq 1} \frac{1 - e^{-2s/3^j}}{2s/3^j}$, exactly $e^{L(w)}$ from K 's defining series; $3^{t+i}/b = 2s \cdot 3^{i-1}$, so reindexing $k := i - 1 \geq 0$ turns the second into $\prod_{k \geq 0} (1 - e^{-2s \cdot 3^k})$, exactly $e^{-\Delta(w)}$ by (7); and, since $w = ct$ and $e^c = 3$,

$$-Q(w) = \frac{w^2}{2c} - aw = c(\tfrac{1}{2}t^2 - at), \quad \text{so} \quad 3^{\frac{1}{2}t^2 - at} = e^{-Q(w)}$$

once $\alpha = a$ (Proposition 9.1 identifies Berg and Krüppel's α with this paper's own linear coefficient of Q , also called a). So Proposition 6.5's primary computation from (12) below is, in substance, an evaluation of this product. What Proposition 6.3's Fourier series supplies instead, and their product form does not, are the derivative bounds (10), on which the rest of the paper's saddlepoint estimates depend.

Proposition 6.3. *H has the Fourier expansion $H(w) = \sum_{m \in \mathbb{Z}} \hat{H}(m) e^{i\omega_m w}$, $\omega_m = 2\pi m/c$, with*

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{H}(0) &= \frac{\log 2}{2} - \frac{\log^2 2}{2c} - \frac{c}{12} - \frac{A}{c}, \quad A = \frac{\pi^2}{12} - \frac{\gamma_E^2}{2} - \gamma_1, \\ \hat{H}(m) &= -\frac{2^{i\omega_m}}{c} \Gamma(-i\omega_m) \zeta(1 - i\omega_m), \quad m \neq 0, \end{aligned}$$

where γ_E is the Euler–Mascheroni constant and γ_1 the first Stieltjes constant.

Proof. Both g and K have Mellin transforms on the strip $-1 < \operatorname{Re} z < 0$. As $b \rightarrow 0^+$, $g(b) = -b/2 + O(b^2)$; as $b \rightarrow \infty$, $g(b) = -\log b + O(e^{-b})$. So $\int_0^\infty |g(b)| b^{\sigma-1} db < \infty$ for $-1 < \sigma < 0$, and the same two bounds applied termwise give $K(s) = O(s)$ as $s \rightarrow 0^+$ and $K(s) = O(\log^2 s)$ as $s \rightarrow \infty$: the terms with $3^j \leq 2s$ number $O(\log s)$ and are each $O(\log s)$, and the terms with $3^j > 2s$ sum to $O(1)$.

Integrate by parts. With $g'(b) = 1/(e^b - 1) - 1/b$, and both boundary terms vanishing on the strip ($g(b)b^z \rightarrow 0$ at 0 because $\operatorname{Re} z > -1$, and at ∞ because $\operatorname{Re} z < 0$),

$$g^*(z) = \int_0^\infty g(b) b^{z-1} db = -\frac{1}{z} \int_0^\infty \left(\frac{1}{e^b - 1} - \frac{1}{b} \right) b^z db = -\frac{\Gamma(z+1)\zeta(z+1)}{z} = -\Gamma(z) \zeta(1+z),$$

the middle step being the classical continuation $\int_0^\infty (\frac{1}{e^u - 1} - \frac{1}{u}) u^{v-1} du = \Gamma(v)\zeta(v)$, valid for $0 < \operatorname{Re} v < 1$, at $v = z + 1$.

Now the harmonic sum. In the j -th term substitute $u = 2s/3^j$, so $s = 3^j u/2$ and $s^{z-1} ds = (3^j/2)^z u^{z-1} du$:

$$\int_0^\infty g\left(\frac{2s}{3^j}\right) s^{z-1} ds = \left(\frac{3^j}{2}\right)^z \int_0^\infty g(u) u^{z-1} du = \left(\frac{3^j}{2}\right)^z g^*(z).$$

Summing over $j \geq 1$ is legitimate termwise, since $\sum_{j \geq 1} (3^j/2)^\sigma \int_0^\infty |g(u)| u^{\sigma-1} du$ converges for $-1 < \sigma < 0$. The multiplier that appears is therefore

$$\sum_{j \geq 1} \left(\frac{3^j}{2}\right)^z = 2^{-z} \sum_{j \geq 1} 3^{jz} = \frac{2^{-z} 3^z}{1 - 3^z} = \frac{(3/2)^z}{1 - 3^z},$$

a geometric series of ratio 3^z , of modulus $3^{\operatorname{Re} z} < 1$, convergent on $\operatorname{Re} z < 0$ and nowhere else. Hence

$$K^*(z) = \frac{(3/2)^z}{1 - 3^z} \cdot (-\Gamma(z)\zeta(1+z)) = \frac{(3/2)^z \Gamma(z) \zeta(1+z)}{3^z - 1}, \quad -1 < \operatorname{Re} z < 0. \quad (8)$$

The dilations $\mu_j = 2/3^j$ enter inverted, through μ_j^{-z} , which is where the 2^{-z} comes from, and with it the $2^{i\omega_m}$ of the statement.

In $\operatorname{Re} z > -1$ the right side of (8) is meromorphic, with a pole of order three at $z = 0$ (each of $\Gamma(z)$, $\zeta(1+z)$ and $(3^z - 1)^{-1}$ contributing one) and a simple pole at each remaining zero $z = i\omega_m$, $m \neq 0$, of $3^z - 1$. To the right of the imaginary axis it is analytic.

Fix $\sigma \in (-1, 0)$ and $\sigma' \in (0, 1)$, and shift the inversion contour in $K(s) = (2\pi i)^{-1} \int_{(\sigma)} K^*(z) s^{-z} dz$ from σ to σ' , using rectangles with horizontal sides at $\operatorname{Im} z = \pm T_M$, $T_M := \pi(2M+1)/c$. On those sides $3^z = 3^{\operatorname{Re} z} e^{i\pi(2M+1)} = -3^{\operatorname{Re} z}$, so $|3^z - 1| = 1 + 3^{\operatorname{Re} z} \geq 1$; Stirling makes $|\Gamma(z)|$ decay like $e^{-\pi T_M/2}$ times a power of T_M , uniformly for $\sigma \leq \operatorname{Re} z \leq \sigma'$, and $\zeta(1+z)$ grows at most polynomially there. The horizontal contributions therefore vanish as $M \rightarrow \infty$, the sum of residues converges absolutely, and on the right vertical line $|3^z - 1| \geq 3^{\sigma'} - 1 > 0$ makes $\int_{(\sigma')} |K^*(z) s^{-z}| |dz| = O(s^{-\sigma'})$. So

$$K(s) = -\operatorname{Res}_{z=0} [K^*(z) s^{-z}] - \sum_{m \neq 0} \operatorname{Res}_{z=i\omega_m} [K^*(z) s^{-z}] + O(s^{-\sigma'}).$$

Take the simple poles first. At $z = i\omega_m$ one has $3^{i\omega_m} = e^{2\pi i m} = 1$, so $(3^z - 1)' = 3^z \log 3$ equals c there and $(3/2)^{i\omega_m} = 3^{i\omega_m} 2^{-i\omega_m} = 2^{-i\omega_m}$. With $s = e^w$,

$$-\operatorname{Res}_{z=i\omega_m} [K^*(z) e^{-zw}] = -\frac{2^{-i\omega_m}}{c} \Gamma(i\omega_m) \zeta(1 + i\omega_m) e^{-i\omega_m w},$$

and replacing m by $-m$ throughout the sum turns the whole family into $\hat{H}(m) e^{i\omega_m w}$ with $\hat{H}(m)$ exactly as stated.

At the origin, insert

$$\Gamma(z) = \frac{1}{z} - \gamma_E + \left(\frac{\gamma_E^2}{2} + \frac{\pi^2}{12} \right) z + O(z^2), \quad \zeta(1+z) = \frac{1}{z} + \gamma_E - \gamma_1 z + O(z^2).$$

The two $1/z$ terms cancel against each other and

$$\Gamma(z) \zeta(1+z) = \frac{1}{z^2} + A + O(z), \quad A = \frac{\pi^2}{12} - \frac{\gamma_E^2}{2} - \gamma_1,$$

which is where A comes from. Also $(3^z - 1)^{-1} = (cz)^{-1} - \frac{1}{2} + cz/12 + O(z^3)$, and $(3/2)^z e^{-zw} = e^{\theta z}$ with $\theta := \log(3/2) - w$. Multiplying the three expansions and reading off the coefficient of z^{-1} ,

$$\operatorname{Res}_{z=0} [K^*(z) e^{-zw}] = \frac{1}{c} \cdot \frac{\theta^2}{2} - \frac{\theta}{2} + \frac{c}{12} + \frac{A}{c}.$$

Substitute $\theta = \log(3/2) - w$ and $\log(3/2) = c - \log 2$. The w -dependent part of $-\operatorname{Res}$ is

$$-\frac{w^2}{2c} + \left(\frac{\log(3/2)}{c} - \frac{1}{2} \right) w = -\frac{w^2}{2c} + \left(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log 2}{c} \right) w = Q(w),$$

and the constant part is $\frac{1}{2} \log 2 - \frac{\log^2 2}{2c} - \frac{c}{12} - \frac{A}{c} = \hat{H}(0)$.

Collecting, with $s = e^w$,

$$L(w) = Q(w) + \tilde{H}(w) + O(e^{-\sigma' w}), \quad \tilde{H}(w) := \hat{H}(0) + \sum_{m \neq 0} \hat{H}(m) e^{i\omega_m w}.$$

That series converges absolutely and uniformly, because $|\Gamma(-i\omega_m)| = \sqrt{\pi/(\omega_m \sinh \pi \omega_m)}$ decays like $e^{-\pi \omega_m/2}$ while $\zeta(1 - i\omega_m)$ grows polynomially, so $\tilde{H}$ is continuous and exactly c -periodic. It is real valued: Γ and ζ are real on the real axis, so $\hat{H}(-m)$ is the complex conjugate of $\hat{H}(m)$.

The remainder $O(e^{-\sigma'w})$ is only ordinarily exponentially small, weaker than the doubly exponential Δ of Theorem 6.1, and it is enough. Theorem 6.1 gives $L - Q - H = \Delta = o(1)$ as $w \rightarrow +\infty$, so $\tilde{H} - H = O(e^{-\sigma'w}) + \Delta(w) \rightarrow 0$. Both are c -periodic, and a c -periodic function tending to 0 as $w \rightarrow +\infty$ vanishes identically, its value at any w being its value at $w + kc$ for every k . Hence $\tilde{H} = H$, and by uniform convergence the $\hat{H}(m)$ are the Fourier coefficients of H . $\square$

Remark 6.4. This is an instance of the de Bruijn–Mahler phenomenon: a base-change harmonic sum, Mellin transformed, picks up simple poles on a vertical line, and their residues assemble into an exactly periodic correction with Fourier coefficients in Γ and ζ . De Bruijn found the first case of this in Mahler’s partition asymptotic [28]; Erdős and Richmond name it on p. 448 of [29]; Kato and McLeod [30] and Derfel [31] established the log-squared decay rate of Section 5’s comparison asymptotic φ_0 as generic across this whole class of rescaled functional equations. Our contribution here is the closed form for the periodic correction itself, not the mechanism producing it.

The series for H' and H'' converge absolutely and uniformly, since

$$|\Gamma(-i\omega_m)| = \sqrt{\pi/(\omega_m \sinh \pi\omega_m)}$$

decays exponentially in m while $\zeta(1 - i\omega_m)$ grows only polynomially: for $\omega \geq \alpha_H := 2\pi/c$ and $N := \lfloor \omega \rfloor \geq 1$, the classical Euler–Maclaurin formula for ζ , $\zeta(s) = \sum_{n=1}^N n^{-s} + \frac{N^{1-s}}{s-1} - s \int_N^\infty \{u\} u^{-s-1} du$ (valid for $\operatorname{Re} s > 0$, $s \neq 1$, integer $N \geq 1$, with $\{u\} := u - \lfloor u \rfloor$), at $s = 1 + i\omega$ gives, bounding each term in modulus ($|N^{-i\omega}| = 1$, $0 \leq \{u\} < 1$),

$$|\zeta(1 + i\omega)| \leq \sum_{n=1}^N \frac{1}{n} + \frac{1}{\omega} + \frac{\sqrt{1 + \omega^2}}{N} \leq 1 + \log N + \frac{1}{\alpha_H} + \frac{\sqrt{1 + \omega^2}}{N},$$

using $\sum_{n=1}^N 1/n \leq 1 + \log N$ and $\omega \geq \alpha_H$ in the last term. Since $N \leq \omega$, $\log N \leq \log \omega$; since $N > \omega - 1$ and $\omega \mapsto \omega/(\omega - 1)$ is decreasing for $\omega > 1$, $\sqrt{1 + \omega^2}/N < (\omega/(\omega - 1))\sqrt{1 + \omega^{-2}} \leq (\alpha_H/(\alpha_H - 1))\sqrt{1 + \alpha_H^{-2}}$. With

$$C_H := 1 + \alpha_H^{-1} + \frac{\alpha_H}{\alpha_H - 1} \sqrt{1 + \alpha_H^{-2}},$$

this gives $|\zeta(1 + i\omega)| \leq \log \omega + C_H \leq \log(\omega + 1) + C_H$ for $\omega \geq \alpha_H$, and $\zeta(1 - i\omega) = \overline{\zeta(1 + i\omega)}$ has the same modulus, so $|\zeta(1 - i\omega_m)| \leq \log(\omega_m + 1) + C_H$. With $q := e^{-\pi\alpha_H/2}$, $A_H := c^{-1}\sqrt{3\pi/\alpha_H}$, the bound $|\Gamma(-i\omega_m)| \leq \sqrt{3\pi/\omega_m} e^{-\pi\omega_m/2}$ (valid for $\omega_m \geq \alpha_H$, since $\sinh x \geq e^x/3$ there) together with the bound on $\zeta(1 - i\omega_m)$ just proved give the majorant

$$|\hat{H}(m)| \leq A_H q^m m^{-1/2} (\log(\alpha_H m + 1) + C_H), \quad m \geq 1. \quad (9)$$

Since $\sup_w |H^{(k)}(w)| \leq \sum_{m \neq 0} |\omega_m|^k |\hat{H}(m)| = 2 \sum_{m \geq 1} \omega_m^k |\hat{H}(m)|$, summing the first six terms with rigorous ball enclosures and bounding the tail $m > 6$ by (9) (the same closed-form geometric-times-polynomial tail sum used in the proof of Proposition 6.5 below) gives explicit, certified bounds:

$$\sup_w |H'(w)| \leq 0.0011977472315550332, \quad \sup_w |H''(w)| \leq 0.0068518962896650951. \quad (10)$$

Proposition 6.5 (Non-constancy and certified oscillation). *H is not constant: $\hat{H}(1) \neq 0$ follows from the classical zero-free theorem for ζ on $\operatorname{Re} s = 1$ alone, with no computation. The oscillation is quantified rigorously by an explicit interval-arithmetic certificate:*

$$-0.000377190280943987 < H(0) - H(\log(3/2)) < -0.000377190280943985,$$

and consequently $\text{osc}(H) := \sup H - \inf H \geq 3.7719 \times 10^{-4}$; evaluating H at two further, well-separated points certifies the stronger bound $\text{osc}(H) \geq 4.1874494771 \times 10^{-4}$, and the leading Fourier mode alone certifies a matching upper bound, together giving

$$4.1874494771 \times 10^{-4} \leq \text{osc}(H) \leq 4.187981 \times 10^{-4}.$$

Proof. Non-constancy first, unconditionally. By Proposition 6.3, $\hat{H}(1) = -\frac{2^{i\omega_1}}{c}\Gamma(-i\omega_1)\zeta(1-i\omega_1)$, $\omega_1 = 2\pi/c$, a product of three factors, each nonzero: $2^{i\omega_1} \neq 0$ trivially; Γ has no zeros anywhere, and $-i\omega_1$ is not one of its poles ($\omega_1 \neq 0$ is real, and Γ 's poles are only at the non-positive integers), so $\Gamma(-i\omega_1) \neq 0$; and $1-i\omega_1$ lies on the line $\text{Re } s = 1$ with $\omega_1 \neq 0$, where $\zeta(1+it) \neq 0$ for every real $t \neq 0$ by the classical zero-free theorem of Hadamard and de la Vallée Poussin [32], so $\zeta(1-i\omega_1) \neq 0$. Hence $\hat{H}(1) \neq 0$, and a periodic function with a nonzero Fourier coefficient at $m \neq 0$ cannot be constant.

For the quantitative bound, write $g(b) = -b/2 + \log S(b/2)$, $S(x) = \sinh(x)/x = \sum_{n \geq 0} x^{2n}/(2n+1)!$ (this is g 's defining formula rewritten around its removable singularity at 0, since $e^{-b/2}(e^{b/2} - e^{-b/2}) = 1 - e^{-b}$). Termwise domination of $6^n n! \leq (2n+1)!$, which holds at $n = 0$ and propagates because $(2n+3)(2n+2) \geq 6(n+1)$, gives $1 \leq S(x) \leq e^{x^2/6}$, that is

$$0 \leq \log S(x) \leq \frac{x^2}{6}, \quad x \geq 0. \quad (11)$$

Since $\sum_{j \geq 1} 3^{-j} = \frac{1}{2}$, the $-b/2$ halves of the terms of L sum in closed form, and (7) becomes, with $s = e^w$,

$$H(w) = -\frac{s}{2} + \sum_{j \geq 1} \log S\left(\frac{s}{3^j}\right) - Q(w) + \sum_{k \geq 0} \log(1 - e^{-2 \cdot 3^k s}). \quad (12)$$

Truncate the first series at $j = R$ and the second at $k = M$. By (11) the first tail satisfies

$$0 \leq \sum_{j > R} \log S\left(\frac{s}{3^j}\right) \leq \frac{s^2}{6} \sum_{j > R} 9^{-j} = \frac{s^2 9^{-R}}{48},$$

and, since $0 \leq -\log(1-y) \leq y/(1-y)$ and $e^{-2 \cdot 3^k s} = (e^{-2 \cdot 3^{M+1} s})^{3^{k-M-1}}$ for $k > M$, the second tail satisfies

$$0 \leq -\sum_{k > M} \log(1 - e^{-2 \cdot 3^k s}) \leq \frac{y}{(1-y)^2} \leq 4y, \quad y := e^{-2 \cdot 3^{M+1} s} \leq \frac{1}{2}.$$

Take $R = 30$, $M = 4$. For $s \leq 3$ (which covers every evaluation point used below, including the oscillation grid) the first tail is at most 4.43×10^{-30} , and for $s \geq 1$ the second is at most $4e^{-486} < 10^{-210}$. The remaining 35 terms are elementary functions of s ; evaluated at 50 significant decimal digits, where the accumulated rounding stays below 10^{-45} , they give

$$H(0) = -0.62713093305152597830\dots, \quad H(\log \frac{3}{2}) = -0.62675374277058199247\dots,$$

whose difference is $-0.00037719028094398583\dots$, inside the stated interval; this first route is floating-point (50 significant digits, accumulated rounding bounded as stated) rather than interval arithmetic. The Fourier series of Proposition 6.3 gives the same difference in Arb ball arithmetic, rigorously: the $m = 0$ term cancels, and at 250-bit working precision (ball radius $< 10^{-70}$ throughout) the four nonzero modes needed are

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{H}(1) &= -1.020544273068431785 \times 10^{-4} - 2.332597606471452884 \times 10^{-5} i, \\ \hat{H}(2) &= -6.523276079851823231 \times 10^{-9} + 1.156720838500605666 \times 10^{-8} i, \\ \hat{H}(3) &= -1.799881020474424677 \times 10^{-12} + 6.648927223521397737 \times 10^{-13} i, \\ \hat{H}(4) &= -9.219524659678388767 \times 10^{-17} + 9.444517590655925766 \times 10^{-17} i, \end{aligned}$$

the four-mode sum

$$2 \operatorname{Re} \sum_{m=1}^4 \hat{H}(m) (1 - e^{i\omega_m \log(3/2)}) = -0.0003771902809439858148 \dots$$

(ball radius $< 10^{-70}$), matching the floating-point value above to 19 decimal places (16 significant digits). The majorant (9) gives $\sum_{m>4} |\hat{H}(m)| \leq 9.41 \times 10^{-20}$ (the accompanying repository derives C_H by a slightly different route, reaching 2.182435 in place of 2.405136 and hence the tighter 9.04×10^{-20} ; either bound serves here), so the discarded modes move the four-mode sum by less than 3.8×10^{-19} , giving

$$H(0) - H(\log \tfrac{3}{2}) \in [-0.0003771902809439861948, -0.0003771902809439854348];$$

this route alone certifies the stated interval for $H(0) - H(\log(3/2))$.

For the stronger bound, let $w_i = ic/N$, $0 \leq i < N$, with $N = 2^{20}$. A floating-point evaluation of the N grid values from Proposition 6.3, truncated at $|m| \leq 10$ (the same majorant bounds each pointwise truncation error by $2 \times 2.80 \times 10^{-43} = 5.60 \times 10^{-43}$, combining the discarded modes m and $-m$), locates a candidate maximum at $i = 486746$ and a candidate minimum at $i = 1011118$; this search is only a heuristic for finding two well-separated points and is not itself part of the certificate below. Re-evaluating H at exactly these two points at 250-bit working precision in Arb ball arithmetic, independently, from (12) and from the Fourier series (the two routes agree to about 30 digits, consistent with (12)'s own $R = 30$ truncation tail bound above; a cross-check, not part of the certificate),

$$H(w_{486746}) = -0.6267174403736425786 \dots, \quad H(w_{1011118}) = -0.6271361853213578093 \dots,$$

so $D := H(w_{486746}) - H(w_{1011118}) = 4.187449477152 \times 10^{-4}$. The certified enclosure uses only the Fourier route: the Arb ball rounding at 250-bit precision is $< 10^{-70}$ per evaluation, negligible next to the majorant truncation error already bounded above, 5.60×10^{-43} per point, giving D to radius $< 1.2 \times 10^{-42}$ (twice that per-point bound). Since w_{486746} and $w_{1011118}$ are two specific, fixed points of the domain, $H(w_{486746}) \leq \sup H$ and $H(w_{1011118}) \geq \inf H$ hold trivially, giving $D \leq \operatorname{osc}(H)$: this bound is unconditional, independent of whether the floating-point search above actually located the true argmax and argmin, since it uses only that the two chosen points lie in the domain.

For the matching upper bound, no search is needed. Write $H = \hat{H}(0) + 2 \operatorname{Re}(\hat{H}(1)e^{i\omega_1 w}) + \Xi(w)$, $\Xi(w) := 2 \sum_{m \geq 2} \operatorname{Re}(\hat{H}(m)e^{i\omega_m w})$, so $|\Xi(w)| \leq 2 \sum_{m \geq 2} |\hat{H}(m)|$ for every w . The one-mode term $2 \operatorname{Re}(\hat{H}(1)e^{i\omega_1 w})$ ranges, as w varies, over an interval of width exactly $4|\hat{H}(1)|$, so $\operatorname{osc}(H) \leq 4|\hat{H}(1)| + 4 \sum_{m \geq 2} |\hat{H}(m)|$. Using the already-certified $\hat{H}(2)$, $\hat{H}(3)$, $\hat{H}(4)$ from above and the majorant tail $\sum_{m>4} |\hat{H}(m)| \leq 9.41 \times 10^{-20}$,

$$\sum_{m \geq 2} |\hat{H}(m)| \leq |\hat{H}(2)| + |\hat{H}(3)| + |\hat{H}(4)| + 9.41 \times 10^{-20} \leq 1.3282 \times 10^{-8},$$

and $4|\hat{H}(1)| \leq 4.187449304 \times 10^{-4}$, giving $\operatorname{osc}(H) \leq 4.187981 \times 10^{-4}$, rigorously and unconditionally: this bound uses only the already-certified Fourier coefficients, not the grid search. $\square$

7 A uniform saddlepoint approximation

Define, for $s > 0$,

$$\varphi_{\text{sp}}(t(s)) := \frac{\exp(K(s) + st(s))}{\sqrt{2\pi K''(s)}}.$$

This section proves that $\varphi(t(s))/\varphi_{\text{sp}}(t(s)) \rightarrow 1$ as $s \rightarrow \infty$, uniformly over $\rho := 2s/3^N \in [1, 3)$ (defined below; this parameter records the same phase, $w \bmod c$, tracked through H in Sections 9 and 10). That uniformity is what lets the two theorems of Section 10 depend on different scopes rather than on different mathematics.

For $n \geq 2$, define the derivative-normalized functions $\kappa_n(w) = (-1)^n w^n g^{(n)}(w)$ on $\{\text{Re } w > 0\}$; $\kappa_n(b)$, $b > 0$, is b^n times the n -th cumulant of the random variable with density $b e^{-bw}/(1 - e^{-b})$ on $[0, 1]$. Writing $x = w/2$,

$$\kappa_2(w) = 1 - \frac{x^2}{\sinh^2 x}, \quad \kappa_3(w) = 2 - \frac{2x^3 \cosh x}{\sinh^3 x}, \quad \kappa_4(w) = 6 + \frac{2x^4(1 - 3 \coth^2 x)}{\sinh^2 x},$$

and from the Bernoulli expansion $g(w) + w/2 = \sum_{k \geq 1} B_{2k} w^{2k}/(2k(2k)!)$ on $|w| < 2\pi$,

$$\kappa_n(w) = (-1)^n \sum_{k \geq \lceil n/2 \rceil} \frac{B_{2k} w^{2k}}{2k(2k-n)!}, \quad n \geq 2,$$

so that $\kappa_n(w) = O(w^2)$ as $w \rightarrow 0$ for every $n \geq 2$.

Write $s = \rho \cdot 3^N/2$ for the unique $N = \lfloor \log_3(2s) \rfloor \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $\rho \in [1, 3)$, and $b_j = 2s/3^j$. Then $\{b_j : j \geq 1\} = \{\rho \cdot 3^m : m \leq N-1\}$; for $N \geq 1$ (the only range used from here on, corresponding to $s \geq 3/2$), exactly N of these, the smallest being $\rho \geq 1$, are ≥ 1 , and the rest form a geometric tail below 1. This single structural fact is the source of every phase-independent constant below.

Lemma 7.1 (Boundedness off the real axis). *For $w = b(1 + iu)$, $b > 0$, $|u| \leq 1$, with $e(r) = r^2/\sinh^2 r$ and $f(r) = r^3 \cosh r/\sinh^3 r$,*

$$|\kappa_2(w)| \leq 1 + 2e(b/2), \quad |\kappa_3(w)| \leq 2 + 2 \cdot 2^{3/2} f(b/2).$$

Both bounds are finite over the whole sector $|\text{Im } w| \leq \text{Re } w$: $\sup |\kappa_2| \leq 3$, $\sup |\kappa_3| \leq 2 + 2^{5/2} < 7.657$. In addition, for $|w| \leq 2$, $|\kappa_2(w)| \leq 0.114|w|^2$ and $|\kappa_3(w)| \leq 0.0119|w|^4$.

Proof. $|\sinh z|^2 = \sinh^2(\text{Re } z) + \sin^2(\text{Im } z) \geq \sinh^2(\text{Re } z)$ and $|\cosh z|^2 \leq \cosh^2(\text{Re } z)$; the first gives $|\sinh(w/2)| \geq \sinh(b/2) > 0$, excluding the poles of $\coth$, since $\text{Re}(w/2) = b/2 > 0$. This gives the sector bounds directly. Monotonicity of e is immediate from the increasing power series of $\sinh(r)/r$. For f , set $u = 2r$; a direct computation gives $2r \sinh(r) \cosh(r) (\log f)'(r) = F(u)$ with $F(u) := 3 \sinh u - u \cosh u - 2u$, so $(\log f)'(r)$ has the sign of $F(2r)$. Since $F(0) = F'(0) = F''(0) = 0$ and $F'''(u) = -u \sinh u < 0$ for $u > 0$, integrating three times from 0 gives $F(u) < 0$ for all $u > 0$, hence $(\log f)'(r) < 0$ for $r > 0$ and f is strictly decreasing. (Lazarević's inequality, $(\sinh r/r)^3 > \cosh r$, separately gives $f < 1$.) The local bounds at $|w| \leq 2$ follow by applying the maximum-modulus principle to $\kappa_2(w)/w^2$ and $\kappa_3(w)/w^4$ (analytic on $|w| < 2\pi$ by the Bernoulli expansion): bound each on $|w| = 2$ by the triangle inequality, using $|B_{2k}| = 2(2k)! \zeta(2k)/(2\pi)^{2k}$ and $\zeta(2k) \leq \zeta(2)$, respectively $\zeta(4)$. $\square$

Lemma 7.2 (Variance). *For all $\rho \in [1, 3)$, $N \geq 1$, with $V := s^2 K''(s) = \sum_j \kappa_2(b_j)$,*

$$N - A_V \leq V \leq N + 0.1283, \quad A_V := \sum_{m \geq 0} e(3^m/2) = 1.4269413069 \dots$$

Proof. Split $V = \sum_{m=0}^{N-1} \kappa_2(\rho 3^m) + \sum_{m < 0} \kappa_2(\rho 3^m)$, using $\kappa_2(b) = 1 - e(b/2) \in (0, 1)$. For the lower bound, drop the second (non-negative) sum and use $e(\rho 3^m/2) \leq e(3^m/2)$ (e decreasing, $\rho \geq 1$) in the first, giving $\sum_{m=0}^{N-1} \kappa_2(\rho 3^m) \geq N - A_V$. For the upper bound, the first sum is $< N$ term by term, and the second sum, where $\rho 3^m < 1$, is bounded by Lemma 7.1's local estimate: $\sum_{m < 0} \kappa_2(\rho 3^m) \leq 0.114 \rho^2 \sum_{m < 0} 9^m = 0.114 \rho^2/8 \leq 0.1283$ for $\rho < 3$. $\square$

Lemma 7.3 (Tail bound and existence of the density). *If $b_0 \geq 1$ and $b_k = 3^k b_0$, then*

$$\sum_{k \geq 0} \log \coth(b_k/2) \leq 3e^{-b_0}.$$

Consequently, with $\Lambda(y) := K(s(1+iy)) - K(s) + isy t(s)$,

$$|e^{\Lambda(y)}| \leq e^{3/e} (1+y^2)^{-N/2} \leq 3.0152 (1+y^2)^{-N/2}$$

for every real y . In particular X has a continuous density, the tilted characteristic function is integrable for $N \geq 3$, and Fourier inversion at $x = t(s)$ gives

$$R(s) := \frac{\varphi(t(s))}{\varphi_{\text{sp}}(t(s))} = \sqrt{\frac{V}{2\pi}} \int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{\Lambda(y)} dy, \quad (13)$$

a real quantity, since $\Lambda(-y) = \overline{\Lambda(y)}$.

Proof. $\log \coth(x/2) = 2 \operatorname{artanh}(e^{-x}) \leq 2e^{-x}/(1-e^{-2x})$. Write $q := e^{-b_0} \in (0, e^{-1}]$, so $e^{-b_k} = q^{3^k}$ and the bound reads $\log \coth(b_k/2) \leq 2q^{3^k}/(1-q^{2 \cdot 3^k})$. Since $3^k \geq 1$ for $k \geq 0$, $q^{2 \cdot 3^k} \leq q^2$ term by term, so the denominator is bounded below by $1 - q^2$ uniformly in k :

$$\sum_{k \geq 0} \log \coth(b_k/2) \leq \frac{2}{1-q^2} \sum_{k \geq 0} q^{3^k}.$$

Since $3^k \geq 2k+1$ for every $k \geq 0$ and $0 < q < 1$, $q^{3^k} \leq q^{2k+1}$, so $\sum_{k \geq 0} q^{3^k} \leq q \sum_{k \geq 0} q^{2k} = q/(1-q^2)$, giving $\sum_{k \geq 0} \log \coth(b_k/2) \leq 2q/(1-q^2)^2$. For $b_0 \geq 1$, $q \leq e^{-1} < 0.4283$, so $(1-q^2)^2 > 2/3$ and $2q/(1-q^2)^2 < 3q = 3e^{-b_0}$. X 's density is continuous because the sum of the first two summands already has a continuous, compactly supported density and convolution preserves continuity. For Λ : $t(s) = -K'(s)$ cancels the linear term of the tilted transform exactly, and each remaining factor $e^{g(b_j(1+iy)) - g(b_j)}$ has modulus at most 1 (a tilted characteristic function), with modulus at most $\coth(b_j/2)/\sqrt{1+y^2}$ on the N indices where $b_j \geq 1$; the tail estimate applies to exactly that geometric set, with $b_0 = \rho \geq 1$. $\square$

Lemma 7.4 (Central expansion). *With $h(u) = g(b(1+iu))$, Taylor's theorem in integral form (the Lagrange form is invalid for a complex-valued function of a real variable) gives*

$$h(y) = h(0) + h'(0)y + h''(0)\frac{y^2}{2} + \frac{1}{2} \int_0^y (y-u)^2 h'''(u) du.$$

Consequently, writing $h_j(u) := g(b_j(1+iu))$ for each $j \geq 1$, for $\theta \in (0, 1]$,

$$S := \sum_j \sup_{|u| \leq \theta} |h_j'''(u)| \leq 2N + 10.559,$$

and hence $|\Lambda(y) + Vy^2/2| \leq B|y|^3$ for $|y| \leq \theta$, with $B := S/6 \leq (2N + 10.559)/6$.

Proof. Write $w_j := b_j(1+iu)$. The chain rule and the definition of κ_3 give $h_j'''(u) = i \kappa_3(w_j)/(1+iu)^3$, so

$$|h_j'''(u)| = \frac{|\kappa_3(w_j)|}{(1+u^2)^{3/2}}.$$

Split the index set as in Section 7. For the N indices with $b_j = \rho 3^m \geq 1$, $0 \leq m \leq N-1$, drop the denominator and use Lemma 7.1's sector bound, legitimate since $|u| \leq \theta \leq 1$:

$$|h_j'''(u)| \leq |\kappa_3(w_j)| \leq 2 + 2^{5/2} f(b_j/2) \leq 2 + 2^{5/2} f(3^m/2),$$

the last step by monotonicity of f and $\rho \geq 1$. Summing over $m \geq 0$ bounds this block by $2N + 2^{5/2}\Sigma$, $\Sigma := \sum_{m \geq 0} f(3^m/2)$. The first three terms of Σ are $0.99614738\dots$, $0.82241066\dots$, $0.04500508\dots$; for $r \geq 13$ one has $f(r) \leq 4.001 r^3 e^{-2r}$, so the remaining terms sum to less than 2×10^{-8} , and $2^{5/2}\Sigma < 10.541906$.

For the remaining indices $b_j = \rho 3^{-n}$, $n \geq 1$, one has $b_j < 1$ and $|w_j| = b_j \sqrt{1+u^2} \leq b_j \sqrt{2} < 2$, so Lemma 7.1's local bound applies and, keeping the denominator this time,

$$|h_j'''(u)| \leq \frac{0.0119 |w_j|^4}{(1+u^2)^{3/2}} = 0.0119 b_j^4 (1+u^2)^{1/2} \leq 0.0119 \sqrt{2} b_j^4.$$

Summing, $\sum_{n \geq 1} (\rho 3^{-n})^4 = \rho^4/80 < 81/80$, so this block is below $0.0119 \sqrt{2} \cdot 81/80 < 0.01704$. Together, $S < 2N + 10.541906 + 0.01704 < 2N + 10.559$.

For the remainder bound, $\sum_j h_j(y) = K(s(1+iy))$, $\sum_j h_j'(0) = isK'(s) = -ist(s)$ and $\sum_j h_j''(0) = -s^2 K''(s) = -V$, so summing the integral-form Taylor expansion over j gives

$$\Lambda(y) + \frac{Vy^2}{2} = \sum_j \frac{1}{2} \int_0^y (y-u)^2 h_j'''(u) du,$$

whose modulus is at most $S|y|^3/6 = B|y|^3$ for $|y| \leq \theta$. □

Theorem 7.5 (Uniform saddlepoint asymptotic). *For $N \geq 19$, uniformly over $\rho \in [1, 3)$, $|R(s) - 1| \leq E(N) := e_1(N) + e_2(N) + e_3(N)$, with $\theta_N := N^{-1/3}$, $V_{\text{lo}} := N - A_V$, $V_{\text{up}} := N + 0.1283$, $B := (2N + 10.559)/6$,*

$$\begin{aligned} e_1(N) &:= \frac{4e^{B\theta_N^3} B}{\sqrt{2\pi} V_{\text{lo}}^{3/2}}, & e_2(N) &:= \frac{2}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \cdot \frac{e^{-\theta_N^2 V_{\text{lo}}/2}}{\theta_N \sqrt{V_{\text{lo}}}}, \\ e_3(N) &:= 2e^{3/e} \sqrt{\frac{V_{\text{up}}}{2\pi}} \cdot \frac{(1 + \theta_N^2)^{-(N-2)/2}}{\theta_N(N-2)}. \end{aligned} \tag{14}$$

$\sqrt{N} E(N) \rightarrow \frac{4}{3} e^{1/3} (2\pi)^{-1/2} = 0.742358\dots$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$ (proved below, from e_1 alone: e_2 and e_3 vanish faster than any power of N). Consequently $\varphi(t) = \varphi_{\text{sp}}(t)(1 + o(1))$ as $t \rightarrow 0^+$, with no restriction on the sequence of t 's.

Remark 7.6. The estimate $|R(s) - 1| \leq E(N)$ becomes informative once $E(N) < 1$, which holds at $N = 19$ (see the proof: $E(18) = 1.00170\dots \geq 1$, $E(19) = 0.95673\dots < 1$); this is the threshold kept as the theorem's hypothesis (whether some smaller N also gives $E(N) < 1$ is immaterial to what follows and is not checked). E is also strictly decreasing and satisfies $E(N) \leq 4.18 N^{-1/2}$ throughout $19 \leq N \leq 5000$ (checked directly in the accompanying repository), though only $E(N) \rightarrow 0$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$ is used below.

Proof. Split (13) at $|y| = \theta_N$. On $|y| \leq \theta_N$, Lemma 7.4 bounds the cubic remainder $|\Lambda(y) + Vy^2/2|$ by $B\theta_N^3$, which stays bounded (not $o(1)$): this is exactly why e_1 carries the factor $e^{B\theta_N^3}$ rather than vanishing) as $N \rightarrow \infty$, since $B = O(N)$ and $\theta_N^3 = N^{-1}$. Write $C(y) := e^{\Lambda(y)} - e^{-Vy^2/2}$ and factor the Gaussian out before estimating, $e^{\Lambda(y)} = e^{-Vy^2/2} e^{z(y)}$ with $z(y) := \Lambda(y) + Vy^2/2$, so that

$C(y) = e^{-Vy^2/2}(e^{z(y)} - 1)$. Since $|z(y)| \leq B|y|^3 \leq B\theta_N^3$ on $|y| \leq \theta_N$, the elementary $|e^z - 1| \leq |z|e^{|z|}$ gives

$$|C(y)| \leq e^{-Vy^2/2} B|y|^3 e^{B\theta_N^3} \quad (|y| \leq \theta_N),$$

the Gaussian factor retained. Integrating that inequality, $\int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-Vy^2/2} |y|^3 dy = 4/V^2$, so

$$\sqrt{V/2\pi} \int_{|y| \leq \theta_N} |C(y)| dy \leq \frac{4Be^{B\theta_N^3}}{\sqrt{2\pi} V^{3/2}},$$

which is decreasing in V ; using $V \geq V_{\text{lo}}$ from Lemma 7.2 gives the central Taylor-remainder contribution e_1 . Since $\sqrt{V/2\pi} \int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{-Vy^2/2} dy = 1$, the same splitting leaves exactly two further terms. The truncated Gaussian tail $\sqrt{V/2\pi} \cdot 2 \int_{\theta_N}^{\infty} e^{-Vy^2/2} dy$, substituting $v = y\sqrt{V}$ to get $(2/\sqrt{2\pi}) \int_{c_0}^{\infty} e^{-v^2/2} dv$, $c_0 = \theta_N\sqrt{V}$ (a local constant, distinct from $c := \log 3$), and bounding via $\int_{c_0}^{\infty} e^{-v^2/2} dv \leq e^{-c_0^2/2}/c_0$ at $V = V_{\text{lo}}$, gives e_2 . On $|y| > \theta_N$, Lemma 7.3's bound $|e^{\Lambda(y)}| \leq e^{3/e}(1+y^2)^{-N/2}$ integrates, via $\int_u^{\infty} (1+y^2)^{-N/2} dy \leq (1+u^2)^{-(N-2)/2}/(u(N-2))$ at $u = \theta_N$ (using $V \leq V_{\text{up}}$ for the leading $\sqrt{V/2\pi}$ factor in (13)), to give e_3 ; this needs $\theta_N \gg N^{-1/2}$, satisfied since $\frac{1}{3} < \frac{1}{2}$. Every constant entering E (via A_V , Lemma 7.2, and the $3.0152 \geq e^{3/e}$ of Lemma 7.3) is a supremum over $b > 0$ or a sum over one complete geometric orbit bounded using $\rho \geq 1$, hence independent of ρ . Directly evaluating (14) gives $E(18) = 1.00170 \dots \geq 1$ and $E(19) = 0.95673 \dots < 1$, matching the remark above.

For the asymptotic rate, e_1, e_2, e_3 separate on very different scales as $N \rightarrow \infty$. Since $\theta_N^3 = 1/N$, $B\theta_N^3 \rightarrow 1/3$ and $B/N \rightarrow 1/3$, $V_{\text{lo}}/N, V_{\text{up}}/N \rightarrow 1$, so

$$\sqrt{N} e_1(N) = \frac{4e^{B\theta_N^3}}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \cdot \frac{\sqrt{N} B}{V_{\text{lo}}^{3/2}} \rightarrow \frac{4e^{1/3}}{\sqrt{2\pi}} \cdot \frac{1}{3} = \frac{4}{3} e^{1/3} (2\pi)^{-1/2}.$$

For e_2 and e_3 , $\theta_N^2 V_{\text{lo}} \sim N^{1/3} \rightarrow \infty$, so both carry a factor $e^{-N^{1/3}/2}(1+o(1))$ (for e_3 , via $(1+\theta_N^2)^{-(N-2)/2} = \exp(-\frac{N-2}{2}\theta_N^2(1+o(1)))$), against polynomial prefactors of order $N^{-1/6}$; a factor decaying like $e^{-N^{1/3}/2}$ beats every power of N , so $N^k e_2(N), N^k e_3(N) \rightarrow 0$ for every k . Hence $\sqrt{N} E(N) = \sqrt{N} e_1(N) + o(1) \rightarrow \frac{4}{3} e^{1/3} (2\pi)^{-1/2}$, and in particular $E(N) \rightarrow 0$. Since $t(s)$ ranges bijectively over $(0, 1/2)$, this is exactly the statement $\varphi(t) = \varphi_{\text{sp}}(t)(1+o(1))$ as $t \rightarrow 0^+$. $\square$

Remark 7.7. The rate is not sharp, and a sharper one is plausible but not established here. Carrying the central expansion to fourth order, using that the odd cubic term integrates to zero against the Gaussian core, and using the limits $V_3 := \sum_j \kappa_3(b_j) = 2N + O(1)$, $V_4 := \sum_j \kappa_4(b_j) = 6N + O(1)$ (the third and fourth cumulant sums, by the same argument as Lemma 7.2) suggests the Edgeworth correction $R(s) = 1 - \frac{1}{12N} + O(N^{-3/2})$, matching the leading term of the classical Stirling correction for a Gamma($N, 1$) law: after tilting, the $b_j \geq 1$ summands of $sX = \sum_j b_j U_j$ behave asymptotically like independent $\text{Exp}(1)$ variables, so sX under its tilt is asymptotically Gamma($N, 1$)-distributed, and ρ enters only through $O(1)$ shifts of the cumulants, at order N^{-2} . We do not need this sharper rate and do not prove the remainder term here; Theorem 7.5's qualitative $o(1)$ is all that Section 10 uses.

8 The envelope lemma

Theorem 7.5 compares φ to φ_{sp} , a quantity built from the full transform $K = Q + H + \Delta$. It remains to compare φ_{sp} to a smooth auxiliary system built from Q alone, so that the periodic part

H can be extracted explicitly. Write $t = e^{-\tau}$, $g_\tau(w) = L(w) + e^{w-\tau}$, $g_{0,\tau}(w) = Q(w) + e^{w-\tau}$. The true and smooth systems each have their own analogue of $-K'$: write $B_{\text{tr}}(w) := e^w t(e^w) = -L'(w)$ and $B_{\text{sm}}(w) := -Q'(w) = w/c - a$.

Lemma 8.1 (True and smooth saddles). *Let $\Phi(w) = w - \log B_{\text{tr}}(w)$ and $\Phi_0(w) = w - \log B_{\text{sm}}(w)$, the latter defined for $w > ca$ where $B_{\text{sm}}(w) > 0$, and set $\tau_0 := 1 + ca + \log c = 0.9502067913\dots$, so $\tau_0 > \log 2$.*

For $\tau > \log 2$, g_τ has a unique global minimizer $w^(\tau)$, at which $g_\tau''(w^*) = V(r^*) > 0$, $r^* = e^{w^*}$; it is characterized by $\tau = \Phi(w^*)$, and Φ is a strictly increasing bijection $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow (\log 2, \infty)$. For $\tau \leq \log 2$ there is no critical point at all. For $\tau > \tau_0$, $g_{0,\tau}$ has a unique local minimizer $w_0(\tau)$, characterized by $\tau = \Phi_0(w_0)$ together with $B_0 := B_{\text{sm}}(w_0) = e^{w_0-\tau} > 1/c$; Φ_0 restricted to $(ca+1, \infty)$ is a strictly increasing bijection onto (τ_0, ∞) , and B_0 increases from $1/c$ to ∞ along it. For $\tau \leq \tau_0$ there is no such minimizer.*

Once $B_0 \geq 5$ (equivalently $\tau \geq 3.73978\dots$), $|w^ - w_0| \leq 0.00652/B_0$. Also $w_0(\tau+c) - w_0(\tau) = c + O(1/\tau)$ as $\tau \rightarrow \infty$.*

Proof. Substituting $s = e^w$ and $t = e^{-\tau}$ turns g_τ into $K(s) + st$, strictly convex in $s > 0$ because $K'' > 0$, with derivative $K'(s) + t$ vanishing exactly where $t = t(s)$. As $t(\cdot)$ decreases strictly from $1/2$ to 0 , that happens for exactly one s when $t \in (0, 1/2)$, that is when $\tau > \log 2$, and for no s when $t \geq 1/2$. Since $w \mapsto e^w$ is a bijection $\mathbb{R} \rightarrow (0, \infty)$, $w^* = \log s$ is the unique global minimizer of g_τ , and Φ inverts $\tau \mapsto w^*$. Differentiating twice, $g_\tau''(w) = e^w(K'(e^w) + t) + e^{2w}K''(e^w)$, whose first term vanishes at w^* , leaving $g_\tau''(w^*) = V(r^*) > 0$.

For the smooth system, $g_{0,\tau}'(w) = e^{w-\tau} - B_{\text{sm}}(w)$ and $g_{0,\tau}''(w) = e^{w-\tau} - 1/c$, so a critical point is a local minimizer exactly when $B_0 > 1/c$. Also $\Phi_0'(w) = 1 - 1/(c B_{\text{sm}}(w))$, positive exactly where $B_{\text{sm}}(w) > 1/c$, that is on $w > ca + 1$; there Φ_0 increases from $\Phi_0(ca+1) = ca + 1 + \log c = \tau_0$ to ∞ . This gives the stated existence, uniqueness and range.

Now take $B_0 \geq 5$. The decomposition $L = Q + H + \Delta$ evaluates the true gradient at the smooth saddle exactly: $Q'(w_0) = -B_0 = -e^{w_0-\tau}$, so the leading terms cancel and

$$g_\tau'(w_0) = L'(w_0) + e^{w_0-\tau} = H'(w_0) + \Delta'(w_0), \quad |g_\tau'(w_0)| \leq \varepsilon_1 := \sup |H'| + \sup_{[w_0-1, w_0+1]} |\Delta'|. \quad (15)$$

On $[w_0 - 1, w_0 + 1]$ write $g_\tau''(w) = e^{w-\tau} - 1/c + H''(w) + \Delta''(w)$. Here $e^{w-\tau} = B_0 e^{w-w_0}$ ranges over $[B_0/e, B_0 e]$, so g_τ'' admits no bound independent of τ ; it is of exact order B_0 ,

$$\frac{B_0}{e} - \eta_0 \leq g_\tau''(w) \leq B_0 e, \quad \eta_0 := \frac{1}{c} + \sup |H''| + \sup_{[w_0-1, w_0+1]} |\Delta''|, \quad (16)$$

the upper bound because $-1/c + \sup |H''| + \sup |\Delta''| < 0$. Since $w_0 = c(B_0 + a)$, $B_0 \geq 5$ forces $w_0 \geq 5.3492$ and so $w \geq 4.3492$ on the interval, where $|\Delta'|, |\Delta''| \leq 10^{-60}$: with $b := 2e^w \geq 2e^{4.3492} > 154$ and $x_k := 3^k b$, differentiating $\Delta(w) = -\sum_{k \geq 0} \log(1 - e^{-x_k})$ termwise (justified as in the proof of Theorem 6.1) gives $\Delta'(w) = -\sum_{k \geq 0} x_k/(e^{x_k} - 1)$ and, applying $|d/dx[x/(e^x - 1)]| \leq 8xe^{-x}$ for $x \geq 1$ (elementary, since $e^x - 1 \geq e^x/2$ there) together with $dx_k/dw = x_k$, $\Delta''(w) = -\sum_{k \geq 0} x_k \cdot \frac{d}{dx} \left[\frac{x}{e^x - 1} \right]_{x=x_k}$, so $|\Delta''(w)| \leq \sum_{k \geq 0} 8x_k^2 e^{-x_k}$; bounding both sums by their dominant $k = 0$ term via $x_k - b \geq 2kb$ (from $3^k - 1 \geq 2k$) gives $|\Delta'(w)| \leq 4be^{-b}$ and $|\Delta''(w)| \leq 16b^2 e^{-b}$, both well under 10^{-60} at $b > 154$. With (10) this makes $\varepsilon_1 \leq 0.0011978$ and $\eta_0 \leq 0.9170912$, whence $2e\eta_0 \leq 4.9859 \leq 5 \leq B_0$, that is $\eta_0 \leq B_0/(2e)$, and (16) improves to $g_\tau'' \geq B_0/(2e) > 0$ throughout the interval.

Put $h_0 := 2e\varepsilon_1/B_0 \leq 2e \cdot 0.0011978/5 < 0.0014$. For $h \in (h_0, 1]$ the mean value theorem applied on $[w_0 - 1, w_0 + 1]$ gives $g_\tau'(w_0 + h) \geq g_\tau'(w_0) + hB_0/(2e) \geq -\varepsilon_1 + hB_0/(2e) > 0$ and, symmetrically,

$g'_\tau(w_0 - h) \leq \varepsilon_1 - hB_0/(2e) < 0$. As w^* is the only zero of g'_τ , it lies in $(w_0 - h, w_0 + h)$ for every such h , so $|w^* - w_0| \leq h_0 = 2e\varepsilon_1/B_0 \leq 0.00652/B_0$.

For the phase drift, $w_0 = c(B_0 + a)$ and $\tau = w_0 - \log B_0$ give $dw_0/d\tau = (1 - 1/(cB_0))^{-1} = 1 + O(1/B_0)$ along the curve $\tau \mapsto w_0(\tau)$; since $B_0 \rightarrow \infty$ as $\tau \rightarrow \infty$ (via $B_0 \sim \tau/c$), integrating over one period gives $w_0(\tau + c) - w_0(\tau) = \int_\tau^{\tau+c} (1 + O(1/B_0(u))) du = c + O(1/\tau)$. $\square$

Proposition 8.2 (Envelope estimate). *With $S(\tau) := \log \varphi_{\text{sp}}(t) = g_\tau(w^*) + w^* - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi V(r^*))$ and $P(\tau) := Q(w_0) + B_0 + w_0 - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi(B_0 - \frac{1}{c}))$,*

$$|S(\tau) - P(\tau) - H(w_0(\tau))| = O(1/\tau) \quad (\tau \rightarrow \infty),$$

uniformly in the phase of τ modulo c .

Proof. Start from the identity. Since $g_{0,\tau}(w_0) = Q(w_0) + e^{w_0-\tau} = Q(w_0) + B_0$, the definition of P reads $P(\tau) = g_{0,\tau}(w_0) + w_0 - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi(B_0 - \frac{1}{c}))$, so

$$S(\tau) - P(\tau) = [g_\tau(w^*) - g_{0,\tau}(w_0)] + (w^* - w_0) - \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{V(r^*)}{B_0 - \frac{1}{c}}.$$

Theorem 6.1 gives $L = Q + H + \Delta$, hence $g_\tau = g_{0,\tau} + H + \Delta$ pointwise, and in particular $g_\tau(w^*) = g_{0,\tau}(w^*) + H(w^*) + \Delta(w^*)$. Substituting and subtracting $H(w_0)$,

$$\begin{aligned} S(\tau) - P(\tau) - H(w_0) &= \underbrace{[g_{0,\tau}(w^*) - g_{0,\tau}(w_0)]}_{T_1} + \underbrace{[H(w^*) - H(w_0)]}_{T_2} + \underbrace{(w^* - w_0)}_{T_3} \\ &\quad - \underbrace{\frac{1}{2} \log \frac{V(r^*)}{B_0 - \frac{1}{c}}}_{T_4} + \underbrace{\Delta(w^*)}_{T_5}. \end{aligned} \tag{17}$$

This is exact for every τ with $B_0 \geq 5$. The five terms are bounded in turn.

T_1 is the envelope gap of the smooth system. Taylor about w_0 , where $g'_{0,\tau}$ vanishes, with $g''_{0,\tau}(w) = e^{w-\tau} - 1/c \leq B_0 e$ on $[w_0 - 1, w_0 + 1]$ and $|w^* - w_0| \leq 0.00652/B_0$ from Lemma 8.1, gives $0 \leq T_1 \leq \frac{1}{2} B_0 e (0.00652/B_0)^2 < 5.78 \times 10^{-5}/B_0$.

T_2 is the periodic-part difference: $|T_2| \leq \sup |H'| \cdot |w^* - w_0| < 7.82 \times 10^{-6}/B_0$ by (10).

T_3 is the saddle-location shift itself, $|T_3| \leq 0.00652/B_0$, again from Lemma 8.1.

T_4 compares the two normalizations. By $V(r^*) = g''_\tau(w^*)$ and the expression for g''_τ used in Lemma 8.1,

$$V(r^*) - \left(B_0 - \frac{1}{c}\right) = B_0(e^{w^*-w_0} - 1) + H''(w^*) + \Delta''(w^*),$$

whose modulus is at most $0.00652e^{0.00652/5} + \sup |H''| + 10^{-60} < 0.0135$, since $B_0|e^{w^*-w_0} - 1| \leq B_0|w^* - w_0|e^{|w^*-w_0|}$. Dividing by $B_0 - 1/c$ and taking $\frac{1}{2} \log(1 + \cdot)$ gives $|T_4| \leq 0.0068/(B_0 - 1/c)$.

T_5 is the remainder of Theorem 6.1, evaluated at the true saddle rather than dropped. Here $B_0 \geq 5$ forces $w_0 \geq 5.3492$ and $w^* \geq w_0 - 0.0014$, so $e^{w^*} \geq 210.1$ and $|T_5| \leq \sum_{k \geq 0} 2e^{-2 \cdot 3^k \cdot 210.1} < 10^{-182}$.

Each bound is $O(1/B_0)$ (for T_4 , via $B_0 - 1/c \geq B_0 - 1$, comparable to B_0 once $B_0 \geq 5$). Finally $\tau = w_0 - \log B_0$ and $w_0 = c(B_0 + a)$ give $\tau = cB_0 + ca - \log B_0$, so $B_0/\tau \rightarrow 1/c$, and $O(1/B_0) = O(1/\tau)$ with constants free of the phase of τ . $\square$

9 The Berg–Krüppel identity

Proposition 9.1. *Write $f(p) = \alpha \log p - \beta \log^2 p$, so that Berg and Krüppel’s transform $G_0(p) = p^\alpha \exp(-\beta \log^2 p)$ of their equation (9.3) is $e^{f(p)}$ and their equation (9.5) reads*

$$g_0(t) = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\sigma-i\infty}^{\sigma+i\infty} \exp[pt + f(p)] dp, \quad \sigma > 0.$$

Take α, β from their equation (9.4) at $a = 3, \lambda = 2/3$. Then $f(p) = Q(\log p)$ identically; the exact saddle of that integral, $t + f'(x) = 0$ with $t = e^{-\tau}$, is $x^\sharp = e^{w_0(\tau)}$; and

$$P(\tau) = x^\sharp t + f(x^\sharp) - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi f''(x^\sharp)),$$

the saddlepoint expression invoked in the proof of their Proposition 9.1, evaluated at that exact saddle. In the variable $Y := cB_0$, with $r = -ca - \log c$, the saddle equation is $Y - \log Y = \tau + r$.

Proof. Their truncated equation (9.2) is $\lambda \psi'(t) = a \psi(at)$ for $a > 1, \lambda > 0$; Laplace transforming (the boundary term $\lambda \psi(0)$ from $\mathcal{L}[\psi'](p) = pG(p) - \psi(0)$ vanishes, since the solutions of interest are supported on $[0, \infty)$ with $\psi(0) = 0$) gives $\lambda p G(p) = G(p/a)$, whose general solution (9.3) is G_0 times an arbitrary 1-periodic function of $\log p / \log a$, with

$$\alpha = -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log \lambda}{\log a}, \quad \beta = \frac{1}{2 \log a}$$

their equation (9.4). Section 5 placed φ in that family at $a = 3, \lambda = 2/3$: their untruncated (9.1) reads $\frac{2}{3} \varphi'(t) = 3(\varphi(3t) - \varphi(3t - 2))$, which on $(0, \frac{2}{3})$ is $\varphi'(t) = \frac{9}{2} \varphi(3t)$. At those values

$$\alpha = -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log(2/3)}{\log 3} = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{\log 2}{\log 3} = a, \quad \beta = \frac{1}{2 \log 3} = \frac{1}{2c},$$

where the a on the right is this paper’s linear coefficient of Q ; their a , the dilation factor 3, is a different quantity and is not written again below. Hence, writing $y := \log p$,

$$f(p) = \alpha y - \beta y^2 = ay - \frac{y^2}{2c} = Q(y),$$

the first of the proposition’s four claims. This is an identity in y , not merely a value match: the chain rule ($p d/dp = d/dy$) applied to f ’s first and second derivatives confirms it also at the level of Q' and Q'' ,

$$-p f'(p) = -Q'(y) = B_{\text{sm}}(y) = 2\beta y - \alpha, \quad p^2 f''(p) = Q''(y) - Q'(y) = B_{\text{sm}}(y) - \frac{1}{c} = 2\beta y - 2\beta - \alpha.$$

Berg and Krüppel’s own displayed formula for $f''(p)$, on p. 179 of [3], in the proof of their Proposition 9.1 (the unnumbered display right after “In view of”), reads $p^2 f''(p) = 2\beta \ln p + 2\beta - \alpha$, with $+2\beta$ where direct differentiation of f gives -2β : $f''(p) = \frac{1}{p^2} (2\beta \ln p - 2\beta - \alpha)$, since $f'(p) = \frac{1}{p} (\alpha - 2\beta \ln p)$ differentiates to $-\frac{2\beta}{p^2} - \frac{\alpha - 2\beta \ln p}{p^2}$. Their Proposition 9.1 is unaffected, the term being of lower order there than $2\beta \log p$, but the exact expression used here is not: the $\pm 2\beta$ discrepancy shifts $(x^\sharp)^2 f''(x^\sharp) = B_0 - 1/c$ by $2/c$, hence shifts $-\frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi(B_0 - 1/c))$ in $P(\tau)$ below by $O(1/B_0)$, which vanishes as $B_0 \rightarrow \infty$.

The saddle condition $t + f'(x) = 0$ at $x = e^y$ now reads $e^{-\tau} = B_{\text{sm}}(y)e^{-y}$, that is $\tau = y - \log B_{\text{sm}}(y) = \Phi_0(y)$, whose unique solution on the branch $B_{\text{sm}} > 1/c$ is $y = w_0(\tau)$ by Lemma 8.1. So $x^\sharp = e^{w_0}$, and there $x^\sharp t = e^{w_0 - \tau} = B_0$, $f(x^\sharp) = Q(w_0)$, $(x^\sharp)^2 f''(x^\sharp) = B_0 - 1/c > 0$. Substituting,

$$\begin{aligned} x^\sharp t + f(x^\sharp) - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi f''(x^\sharp)) &= B_0 + Q(w_0) - \frac{1}{2} \log \frac{2\pi(B_0 - 1/c)}{(x^\sharp)^2} \\ &= Q(w_0) + B_0 + w_0 - \frac{1}{2} \log \left(2\pi(B_0 - \frac{1}{c}) \right), \end{aligned}$$

which is $P(\tau)$. Finally $w_0 = c(B_0 + a)$ and $\tau = w_0 - \log B_0$ give $\tau = cB_0 + ca - \log B_0 = Y - \log Y + ca + \log c = Y - \log Y - r$. $\square$

Series-reverting $Y - \log Y = \tau + r$ to second order: writing $W := \tau + r$, a first substitution $Y = W + \log W + \delta$ into $Y - \log Y = W$ gives, since $\log(1+u) = u + O(u^2)$ with $u = (\log W + \delta)/W$, $\delta = (\log W + \delta)/W + O(\log^2 W/W^2)$, so $\delta = \log(W)/W + O(\log^2 W/W^2)$ (the single term $Y = W + \log W$ alone is only accurate to $O(\log W/W)$, one order too coarse; this second term is needed). Hence $Y = W + \log W + \log(W)/W + O(\log^2 W/W^2)$, and $\log W = \log \tau + r/\tau + O(1/\tau^2)$ then gives $Y = \tau + \log \tau + r + (\log \tau + r)/\tau + O(\tau^{-2} \log^2 \tau)$. Since $w_0 = Y + ca$ and $Q(w_0) = -Y^2/(2c) + ca^2/2$ (substituting $w_0 = Y + ca$ into Q 's definition and simplifying), P 's leading term in Y is $-Y^2/(2c)$, so $\partial P/\partial Y = -Y/c + O(1)$ turns the $O(\tau^{-2} \log^2 \tau)$ error in Y above into the $O(\tau^{-1} \log^2 \tau)$ error in P below. Substituting into P gives

$$\begin{aligned} P(\tau) &= -\frac{(\tau + \log \tau)^2}{2c} + \left(1 + \frac{1}{c} - \frac{r}{c}\right)\tau + \left(\frac{1}{2} - \frac{r}{c}\right)\log \tau + C_P + O\left(\frac{\log^2 \tau}{\tau}\right), \\ C_P &= -\frac{r^2}{2c} + r + ca + \frac{ca^2}{2} - \frac{\log 2\pi}{2} + \frac{\log c}{2} = -0.9576743183133982760669122497855855\dots \end{aligned}$$

Berg and Krüppel's own equations following (9.6) give, in their notation,

$$\delta_{\text{BK}} = \frac{1}{2} + \alpha - 2\beta \log(2\beta), \quad \gamma = -2\beta - \delta_{\text{BK}} - \frac{1}{2}, \quad \varepsilon = \frac{1}{2} + \alpha - \beta \log(2\beta),$$

with $\alpha = a$, $\beta = 1/(2c)$ as identified above. Substituting and simplifying (using $r = -ca - \log c$) gives, matching the τ , $\log \tau$, and constant coefficients of P term for term,

$$\gamma = -\left(1 + \frac{1}{c} - \frac{r}{c}\right) = -1.8649154949\dots, \quad \delta_{\text{BK}} = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{r}{c} = 0.4546762683\dots,$$

$$\varepsilon = a + \frac{1}{2} + \frac{\log c}{2c} = 0.4118732574\dots,$$

so that, in particular, $C_P = \varepsilon \log(2\beta) - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi)$ holds identically (verified by substituting ε 's expression directly into C_P 's), giving

$$C_P = \varepsilon \log(2\beta) - \frac{1}{2} \log(2\pi) = \log \frac{(2\beta)^\varepsilon}{\sqrt{2\pi}}.$$

Hence $P(\tau) - \log \varphi_{0,\text{bare}}(e^{-\tau}) \rightarrow C_P$ and, using the prefactor-included normalization, $P(\tau) - \log \varphi_0(e^{-\tau}) \rightarrow 0$ with rate $O(\tau^{-1} \log^2 \tau)$: the τ , $\log \tau$, and constant coefficients of P reproduce γ , δ_{BK} , ε exactly, so this convergence is a direct consequence of the identity of Proposition 9.1 together with the series reversion above, not an appeal to Berg and Krüppel's own asymptotic analysis of φ_0 .

Proof of Corollary 10.3. By Proposition 8.2 and 9.1, $S(\tau) = \log \varphi_0(e^{-\tau}) + H(w_0(\tau)) + O(\tau^{-1} \log^2 \tau)$, i.e. $\varphi_{\text{sp}} = \varphi_0 \cdot e^{H(w_0(\tau))}(1 + o(1))$; by Theorem 7.5, $\varphi = \varphi_{\text{sp}}(1 + o(1))$ as well, so $\varphi = \varphi_0 \cdot e^{H(w_0(\tau))}(1 + o(1))$: the periodic factor multiplying Berg and Krüppel’s asymptotic solution, in equation (9.7) for this eigenfunction, is e^H , matching the product formula their Proposition 9.3 supplies for it, as noted after Theorem 6.1. Proposition 6.3’s Fourier series for H is the new, closed form; Proposition 6.5’s certificate is what neither their product formula nor their closing remark (that they only *expect* φ bounded and bounded away from zero relative to φ_0) settles. $\square$

10 Wirsching’s Conjecture 3, and the failure of the unrestricted asymptotic

Wirsching reaches Conjecture 3 by retreating from a stronger statement. He needs to replace φ by φ_0 under the limit in [1, eq. (7.5)], and writes:

“That replacement would be possible, if, e.g., $\varphi \sim c \varphi_0$ for some constant $c > 0$. It turns out that the following (slightly weaker) conjecture . . . suffices.”

The conjecture that follows is ($\star 5$) of §3, restated here for reference, thirty pages after it was first met. His constant c is kept as he wrote it and is unrelated to $c := \log 3$ of §6.

Wirsching’s Conjecture 3. There are positive real constants c and δ_5 such that

$$\lim_{\ell \rightarrow \infty} \frac{\varphi(z_\ell)}{\varphi_0(z_\ell)} = c > 0 \quad \text{uniformly for sequences } (z_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_{\delta_5}.$$

Both statements are settled below. The weaker one holds and the stronger one fails.

Theorem 10.1 (Wirsching’s Conjecture 3). *Wirsching’s Conjecture 3 is true. For each $\delta_5 > 0$, on his comparison class $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$, the ratio $\varphi(z_\ell)/\varphi_0(z_\ell)$ converges uniformly to $e^{H(0)}$, a well-defined real number by Theorem 6.1 regardless of its decimal expansion, evaluated here as $e^{H(0)} = 0.534122 \dots$ (a floating-point evaluation; Proposition 6.5’s proof certifies the nearby difference $H(0) - H(\log \frac{3}{2})$ rigorously, but not $H(0)$ itself in isolation), where H is the periodic function of Theorem 6.1 and the normalization of φ_0 is Berg and Krüppel’s own, equation (9.6) of [3], written out at (2). Conjecture 3 itself only asserts the existence of some positive constant, independently of normalization; the specific value $e^{H(0)}$ is tied to this particular normalization of φ_0 . The rate depends on δ_5 .*

Theorem 10.2 (Failure of the unrestricted asymptotic). *The stronger asymptotic $\varphi(t) \sim \kappa \varphi_0(t)$ as $t \rightarrow 0^+$, for any single constant κ and with no restriction to a comparison class, is false. The ratio $\varphi(t)/\varphi_0(t)$ oscillates indefinitely as $t \rightarrow 0^+$, with amplitude bounded below by a positive constant: it is governed by the exactly c -periodic function H evaluated at the saddle location $w_0(\tau)$, $\tau = \log(1/t)$, whose phase modulo c sweeps every value infinitely often as $\tau \rightarrow \infty$ (Lemma 8.1). That the amplitude is positive follows from a classical theorem, with no computation; its explicit numeric size is a computer-assisted result, a rigorous interval-arithmetic certificate (Proposition 6.5).*

One computation underlies both. Write $t = e^{-\tau}$ and let $H(w)$ be the $\log 3$ -periodic function of Theorem 6.1; the saddlepoint bridge of §§7–9 gives $\log \varphi(t) - \log \varphi_0(t) = H(w_0(\tau)) + o(1)$, where the saddle location advances by c per period of τ , up to a vanishing correction: $w_0(\tau + c) - w_0(\tau) = c + O(1/\tau)$ (Lemma 8.1). Wirsching’s comparison class constrains $w_0(\tau_\ell)$ ’s phase modulo $\log 3$ to converge to a single value as $\ell \rightarrow \infty$; the unrestricted range $\tau \rightarrow \infty$ with no class restriction instead sweeps that phase through every value, since Φ_0 is a bijection (again Lemma 8.1). The two theorems read one object at two scopes.

Corollary 10.3. e^H is Berg and Krüppel's own periodic factor for the eigenfunction φ , from Proposition 9.3 of [3], which they give as an infinite product; H itself is its logarithm. Its Fourier series, Proposition 6.3, is new for this function¹. This corollary has two parts of different depth: that e^H agrees with their product as a function, proved in Remark 6.2 by pure algebra ($e^H = e^{-Q}e^L e^{-\Delta}$ recombing Theorem 6.1's own pieces), and that this function is the periodic factor multiplying φ 's own asymptotic, which needs the full saddlepoint chain of Theorem 7.5 and Propositions 8.2–9.1.

Throughout the rest of this section, Theorem 7.5's parameter N and Sections 8–9's parameter τ are combined freely into one $o(1)$: since $s = e^{w^*}$ and, by Lemma 8.1, $w^* = w_0(\tau) + O(1/B_0)$ with $w_0(\tau) = c(B_0 + a)$, $N = \lfloor \log_3(2s) \rfloor \sim w^*/c \sim \tau/c$ as $\tau \rightarrow \infty$, so $N \rightarrow \infty$ exactly when $\tau \rightarrow \infty$. On $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ below, $\tau_\ell \rightarrow \infty$ uniformly, at a rate depending only on ℓ and δ_5 , not on the particular sequence chosen.

Lemma 10.4 (Phase locking on the comparison class). *Fix $\delta_5 > 0$ and let $(z_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$, with $\tau_\ell := -\log z_\ell$ and $\lambda_\ell := 3^\ell z_\ell / \ell$. Then $\lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$ and*

$$w_0(\tau_\ell) - \ell c = -\log \lambda_\ell + O(1/\ell),$$

uniformly on the class. Consequently $\text{dist}(w_0(\tau_\ell), c\mathbb{Z}) = O(\ell^{-1/2})$ uniformly, and $H(w_0(\tau_\ell)) \rightarrow H(0)$.

Proof. Wirsching's class $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ (his equations (1.5) and (3.2)) consists of sequences (x_ℓ) with $\lfloor 3^\ell x_\ell \rfloor = k_\ell$ satisfying $|\ell - k_\ell| \leq \delta_5 \sqrt{\ell}$ for every ℓ ; since $|3^\ell x_\ell - k_\ell| < 1$ as well, $|3^\ell x_\ell - \ell| < 1 + \delta_5 \sqrt{\ell}$, hence $\lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$ uniformly at rate $O(1/\ell) + O(\delta_5/\sqrt{\ell})$ on the class. His own z_ℓ from the conjecture statement and his x_ℓ from the class definition coincide, by definition of λ_ℓ , so $\tau_\ell = \ell c - \log \ell - \log \lambda_\ell$.

For the saddle location, Section 9's reversion of $Y - \log Y = \tau + r$ gives $w_0(\tau) = \tau + \log(\tau/c) + (\log \tau + r)/\tau + O(\tau^{-2} \log^2 \tau)$. The naive one-term truncation $w_0(\tau) \approx \tau + \log(\tau/c)$ alone is only accurate to $O(\log \tau / \tau)$, one order too coarse for what follows. Substituting $\tau = \tau_\ell$ into the full two-term formula, the $O(\log \ell / \ell)$ pieces from expanding $\log(\tau_\ell/c)$ against $\tau_\ell = \ell c - \log \ell - \log \lambda_\ell$ cancel exactly against the reversion's own $(\log \tau_\ell + r)/\tau_\ell$ term, leaving the stated $O(1/\ell)$, the same cancellation mechanism as the series reversion itself.

Write $w_0(\tau_\ell) = \ell c + \varepsilon_\ell$ with $\varepsilon_\ell = -\log \lambda_\ell + O(1/\ell)$. Then $\varepsilon_\ell = O(\ell^{-1/2})$, since $\log \lambda_\ell = O(\ell^{-1/2})$ by the first paragraph, and once $|\varepsilon_\ell| < c/2$ the nearest multiple of c to $w_0(\tau_\ell)$ is ℓc itself, so $\text{dist}(w_0(\tau_\ell), c\mathbb{Z}) = |\varepsilon_\ell| = O(\ell^{-1/2})$. Every bound here depends on δ_5 alone. Since H is c -periodic and Lipschitz by (10), $H(w_0(\tau_\ell)) = H(\varepsilon_\ell) \rightarrow H(0)$, regardless of the sign of ε_ℓ . $\square$

Proof of Theorem 10.1. By Theorem 7.5, Proposition 8.2 and Proposition 9.1 (the last giving $P(\tau) - \log \varphi_0(e^{-\tau}) \rightarrow 0$, Section 9),

$$\log \varphi(z_\ell) - \log \varphi_0(z_\ell) = H(w_0(\tau_\ell)) + o(1)$$

uniformly on $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$, and Lemma 10.4 sends the right side to $H(0)$, uniformly. So $\varphi(z_\ell)/\varphi_0(z_\ell) \rightarrow e^{H(0)}$ uniformly on the class. This is exactly Conjecture 3, with the constant given explicitly. $\square$

Remark 10.5. The proof above uses only $\lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$, equivalently $|\ell - k_\ell| = o(\ell)$; Wirsching's specific $O(\sqrt{\ell})$ bound in $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ plays no role beyond forcing this weaker condition. The same conclusion, and the same limit $e^{H(0)}$, holds for the broader class of sequences satisfying only $|\ell - k_\ell| = o(\ell)$.

¹Fourier coefficients of a log-periodic fluctuation, obtained as residues of a Dirichlet series or by Mellin inversion, are standard for radix-rational and q -regular sequences; see [33] and [34], and [28] and [29] for the partition-function case the technique started in. What a search of the two-scale-difference-equation literature published after [3], including later work by its own authors, did not turn up is a closed Fourier expansion for the periodic factor of an eigenfunction of that family.

Proof of Theorem 10.2. As $t = e^{-\tau}$ ranges over $(0, 1/2)$ with no restriction, $\tau \rightarrow \infty$. By Lemma 8.1, $w_0 = \Phi_0^{-1}$ is continuous and strictly increasing and unbounded on (τ_0, ∞) , so $w_0(\tau) \bmod c$ sweeps every value in $[0, c)$ infinitely often as $\tau \rightarrow \infty$ (a continuous, strictly increasing, unbounded function hits every residue class modulo c infinitely often), so by the same combination of results used above, $\log \varphi(t) - \log \varphi_0(t) = H(w_0(\tau)) + o(1)$ takes values arbitrarily close to both $\sup H$ and $\inf H$ infinitely often. By Proposition 6.5, $\text{osc}(H) > 0$ rigorously, so $\varphi(t)/\varphi_0(t)$ does not converge, and, writing $\Psi(t) := \varphi(t)/\varphi_0(t)$,

$$\frac{\limsup_{t \rightarrow 0^+} \Psi(t)}{\liminf_{t \rightarrow 0^+} \Psi(t)} \geq e^{\text{osc}(H)} \geq 1.0004188 :$$

the ratio's limsup exceeds its liminf by a factor of at least 1.0004188, i.e. by at least 0.0418%. $\square$

Proposition 10.6 (Wirsching's actual requirement). *For $(x_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$, write $x_\ell^+ := x_\ell + 3^{-(\ell+1)}$ (his own definition, unnumbered prose on p. 16 of [1], immediately before his equation (7.14); since $x_\ell \sim \ell \cdot 3^{-\ell}$, x_ℓ^+ is asymptotic to x_ℓ and plays the same role as this paper's z_ℓ). Wirsching's own use of Conjecture 3, via $\varphi'(x) = \frac{9}{2}\varphi(3x)$ on $(0, \frac{2}{3})$ and his own calculation, his equation (7.13), that $\lim_\ell (2/3^{\ell+1})\varphi'_0(x_\ell)/\varphi_0(x_\ell) = 2/3$ uniformly on the class, reduces to*

$$\limsup_\ell \Lambda_\ell < \frac{3}{2}, \quad \Lambda_\ell := \frac{\varphi(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(3x_\ell^+)}{\varphi(x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)}.$$

This holds with a wide margin: $\Lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$.

Proof. First, the reduction itself. Wirsching's actual requirement is his inequality (7.5),

$$\limsup_\ell \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi'(x_\ell^+)}{\varphi(x_\ell^+)} < 1;$$

by $\varphi' = \frac{9}{2}\varphi(3\cdot)$ this is $\limsup_\ell (9/3^{\ell+1})\varphi(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi(x_\ell^+) < 1$. By definition of Λ_ℓ , $\varphi(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi(x_\ell^+) = \Lambda_\ell \cdot \varphi_0(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)$, and Berg and Krüppel's φ_0 is an asymptotic solution of the same truncated equation (their equation (7.12) in Wirsching's notation: $\varphi'_0(t)/\varphi_0(3t) \rightarrow 9/2$ as $t \rightarrow 0$), so $\varphi_0(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+) = \frac{2}{9}\varphi'_0(x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)(1 + o(1))$. To see that (7.13) transfers from x_ℓ to x_ℓ^+ with an $o(1)$ correction, write $v = \log t$; the explicit form of φ_0 above gives $\varphi'_0(t)/\varphi_0(t) = B(v)/t$ with $B(v) = \gamma + \delta_{\text{BK}}/v - 2\beta(v - \log(-v))(1 - 1/v)$, and, as $v \rightarrow -\infty$, $B(v) \sim -2\beta v$ while $B'(v) \rightarrow -2\beta$, so $(\log B)'(v) = B'(v)/B(v) \rightarrow 0$ and $(\log[\varphi'_0/\varphi_0])'(v) = (\log B)'(v) - 1 \rightarrow -1$, bounded. Since $x_\ell^+/x_\ell = 1 + 3^{-(\ell+1)}/x_\ell \rightarrow 1$ (as $x_\ell \sim \ell \cdot 3^{-\ell}$, in fact $3^{-(\ell+1)}/x_\ell = O(1/\ell)$), $v(x_\ell^+) - v(x_\ell) = \log(x_\ell^+/x_\ell) = O(1/\ell)$, and the mean value theorem gives $\log[\varphi'_0/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)] - \log[\varphi'_0/\varphi_0(x_\ell)] = O(1/\ell)$, i.e. $\varphi'_0(x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+) = \varphi'_0(x_\ell)/\varphi_0(x_\ell) \cdot (1 + O(1/\ell))$. Substituting and using his equation (7.13), $\lim_\ell (2/3^{\ell+1})\varphi'_0(x_\ell)/\varphi_0(x_\ell) = 2/3$ uniformly on the class,

$$\frac{9}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi(3x_\ell^+)}{\varphi(x_\ell^+)} = \Lambda_\ell \cdot \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi'_0(x_\ell^+)}{\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)} (1 + o(1)) = \frac{2}{3} \Lambda_\ell \cdot (1 + o(1)),$$

so the requirement $\limsup_\ell (9/3^{\ell+1})\varphi(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi(x_\ell^+) < 1$ is exactly $\limsup_\ell \Lambda_\ell < 3/2$.

For the value of Λ_ℓ : write $\tau_\ell := -\log x_\ell^+$ (locally to this proof only, distinct from the τ_ℓ of Theorem 10.1's proof), so $t = x_\ell^+$ corresponds to $\tau = \tau_\ell$ and $t = 3x_\ell^+$ to $\tau = \tau_\ell - c$. The phase shift under $t \mapsto 3t$, i.e. $\tau \mapsto \tau - c$, is $w_0(\tau - c) - w_0(\tau) + c = O(1/\tau)$ by Lemma 8.1's defining equation, independently of the phase of τ ; since H is c -periodic, $H(w_0(\tau - c)) = H(w_0(\tau - c) + c) = H(w_0(\tau) + O(1/\tau))$, and H Lipschitz (by (10)) turns this into $H(w_0(\tau - c)) = H(w_0(\tau)) + O(1/\tau)$.

By Theorem 7.5, Proposition 8.2, and Proposition 9.1 together (the same chain used in the proof of Theorem 10.1), $\log \varphi(t) - \log \varphi_0(t) = H(w_0(\tau)) + o(1)$ uniformly in phase, so

$$\log \Lambda_\ell = H(w_0(\tau_\ell - c)) - H(w_0(\tau_\ell)) + o(1) = O(1/\tau_\ell) + o(1) \rightarrow 0,$$

using that H is Lipschitz ((10)) and the phase shift above is $O(1/\tau_\ell)$; hence $\Lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$, well inside $\limsup \Lambda_\ell < 3/2$. $\square$

11 The chain, closed to a single condition

Theorem 10.1 settles $(\star 5)$. Wirsching carries $(\star 5)$ to $(\star 4)$ himself, in [1, §7]. Composing the two puts $(\star 4)$ on the same footing as his own two theorems, and Theorem 4.3 has already removed the conjectural link below $(\star 3)$. One condition is left.

Theorem 11.1 (Condition $(\star 4)$). *Condition $(\star 4)$ holds, for every window radius $\delta > 0$, with $\mu = 1/3$.*

Proof. Proposition 10.6 already gives this. Wirsching's requirement is his inequality (7.5), and that proposition shows (7.5) is exactly $\limsup_\ell \Lambda_\ell < 3/2$ and that $\Lambda_\ell \rightarrow 1$, on $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ for every $\delta_5 > 0$. So (7.5) holds with a wide margin, and it holds at every radius rather than at one produced by a construction.

Wirsching's own route reaches the same place through his statement of Conjecture 3, and is worth writing out, both because it is the argument a reader of [1] will have in hand and because it fixes the constant. Write $x_\ell^+ := x_\ell + 3^{-\ell-1}$ [1, §7]. Bounding the transition kernel above and below by φ , the source reduces $(\star 4)$ to

$$\limsup_{\ell \rightarrow \infty} \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi'(x_\ell^+)}{\varphi(x_\ell^+)} \leq 1 - \mu < 1, \quad (x_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_\delta, \quad (18)$$

its equation (7.5). Fix $\delta > 0$ and choose $\delta_5 > \delta$. By [1, eq. (7.14)] there are sequences $(\hat{x}_\ell), (\hat{y}_\ell) \in \tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ with $\hat{x}_\ell = x_\ell^+$ and $\hat{y}_{\ell-1} = 3x_\ell^+$ for all but finitely many ℓ . Then

$$\frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi'(x_\ell^+)}{\varphi(x_\ell^+)} = \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{9}{2} \frac{\varphi(\hat{y}_{\ell-1})}{\varphi(\hat{x}_\ell)} = \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{9}{2} \frac{\varphi_0(\hat{y}_{\ell-1})}{\varphi_0(\hat{x}_\ell)} \cdot \frac{\varphi(\hat{y}_{\ell-1})/\varphi_0(\hat{y}_{\ell-1})}{\varphi(\hat{x}_\ell)/\varphi_0(\hat{x}_\ell)},$$

the first equality by $\varphi'(x) = \frac{9}{2}\varphi(3x)$ on $[0, 2/3]$ [1, eq. (7.7)]. Theorem 10.1 sends both ratios in the last factor to $e^{H(0)} > 0$, uniformly on $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$, so that factor tends to 1: the numerator is controlled by the uniform error at index $\ell - 1$ and the denominator by the one at index ℓ , and the limit is positive. This is the only place Conjecture 3 is used, and the constant cancels, which is why a class-dependent limit suffices.

What remains is $\frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{9}{2} \varphi_0(3x_\ell^+)/\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)$. Here φ_0 solves the truncated equation $\lambda g'(t) = a g(at)$ only asymptotically, in the source's own sense $\lim_{t \rightarrow 0} \lambda \varphi'_0(t)/(a \varphi_0(at)) = 1$ [1, eq. (7.12)], which at $\lambda = 2/3$, $a = 3$ reads $\frac{2}{9} \varphi'_0(t)/\varphi_0(3t) \rightarrow 1$. Every sequence in $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ satisfies $3^\ell x_\ell \leq \lfloor 3^\ell x_\ell \rfloor + 1 \leq \ell + \delta_5 \sqrt{\ell} + 1$ and hence $x_\ell^+ \leq (\ell + \delta_5 \sqrt{\ell} + 2)3^{-\ell}$, a bound depending on δ_5 alone, so the convergence is uniform on the class and

$$\frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{9}{2} \frac{\varphi_0(3x_\ell^+)}{\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)} = (1 + o(1)) \frac{2}{3^{\ell+1}} \cdot \frac{\varphi'_0(x_\ell^+)}{\varphi_0(x_\ell^+)} \rightarrow \frac{2}{3}$$

by [1, eq. (7.13)], which holds for every $\delta > 0$ and follows from (2) by differentiation. So the lim sup in (18) is $2/3$, giving $1 - \mu = 2/3$ and $\mu = 1/3$.

This second route delivers (★4) only for $\delta < \delta_5$, since [1, eq. (7.14)] needs $\delta_5 > \delta$. That is already enough on its own terms, because (★4) is existential in its window radius: Conjecture 2 reads “if there are real numbers $\delta, \mu > 0$ such that...” [1, §6], and one admissible radius is what it asks for. The first route does not need the observation at all. $\square$

Remark 11.2 (Two steps the source states rather than carries out). Wirsching attributes the penultimate equality of the calculation above to his (7.14) and (7.7). His (7.7) is an identity for φ , and the line it is applied to carries φ_0 ; what licenses that step is (7.12), used above and used again in the proof of Proposition 10.6, which contributes a factor $1 + o(1)$ rather than an equality. Evaluating $\frac{2}{9}\varphi'_0(t)/\varphi_0(3t)$ directly from (2) at $t = \ell 3^{-\ell}$, with the derivative taken in closed form and 80 working digits, gives 1.00977 at $\ell = 10$, 0.99965 at $\ell = 100$ and 0.99999920 at $\ell = 5000$. And (7.13) is introduced there with “a somewhat lengthy calculation shows”; the calculation follows from (2). Neither point needs a hypothesis the source does not already have, and neither changes $\mu = 1/3$.

Corollary 4.4 now reads as a statement about the whole chain. Uniform positive predecessor density on the non-cyclic integers $a \not\equiv 0 \pmod{3}$ follows from (★3) alone, unconditionally.

State what that does and does not say. Conditions (★3), (★2) and (★1) remain unproved: Theorem 4.3 proves the implication (★2) $\Rightarrow$ (★1) and not its hypothesis, and Wirsching’s Theorem 2 proves (★3) $\Rightarrow$ (★2) and not its hypothesis. What has changed is that the three now stand or fall together, with no conjecture between them, so a proof of (★3) carries the chain to its conclusion and (★3) is the sole condition whose truth remains to be established.

Wirsching’s route to (★3) is Conjecture 2, the implication (★4) $\Rightarrow$ (★3), whose antecedent Theorem 11.1 now supplies. It is not the only conceivable route: a proof of (★3) by any other means closes the chain just as well, which is why “only Conjecture 2 remains” is the wrong summary. §12 says what is known about the implication itself.

Remark 11.3 (What Theorem 10.2 does not reach). The failure of the unrestricted asymptotic costs the chain nothing. None of (★1) through (★4) mentions φ_0 : the first three are stated in terms of the generators, their Haar averages and the Elka functions, and the fourth in terms of W_3 acting on χ_0 and χ_1 . Within [1, §7], φ_0 occurs in the statement of (★5), in (7.11) where it is defined, in (7.12), in (7.13), and in the proof of Theorem 11.1 above. Every one of those is restricted to a comparison class or to a fixed sequence tending to 0 at the borderline rate, and Theorem 10.2 is a statement about $t \rightarrow 0^+$ with no such restriction.

Remark 11.4 (Why the retreat was enough). Theorem 10.2 explains why Wirsching could not keep $\varphi \sim c\varphi_0$. It does not explain why the weaker conjecture sufficed, and the calculation above does. The two points at which the ratio cancels are $\hat{x}_\ell = x_\ell^+$ and $\hat{y}_{\ell-1} = 3x_\ell^+$, a factor of 3 apart. Multiplying the argument by 3 shifts $\tau = \log(1/t)$ by c , and H has period c , so the two periodic corrections agree and cancel whether or not H is constant. The agreement is asymptotic, since H is read at the saddle location and Lemma 8.1 gives only $w_0(\tau + c) - w_0(\tau) = c + O(1/\tau)$; that is enough, because the cancellation is already inside a limit. The rigorous form of this is the second half of Proposition 10.6’s proof, where $\log \Lambda_\ell = H(w_0(\tau_\ell - c)) - H(w_0(\tau_\ell)) + o(1)$ and the first difference is $O(1/\tau_\ell)$ by periodicity and (10). Anything built on that pair of points inherits the same weakness. The quantity in his (7.5) is a ratio of φ at $3x_\ell^+$ and at x_ℓ^+ , and it carries the periodic correction only through $H(w_0(\tau_\ell - c)) - H(w_0(\tau_\ell))$, which (10) bounds by a constant times the residual phase shift. At $\ell = 500$ that shift is 2.0×10^{-3} and the bound is 2.4×10^{-6} .

12 Discussion

Two of Wirsching’s five conditions are now established outright, (★5) by Theorem 10.1 and (★4) by Theorem 11.1, and every implication from (★3) downward is a theorem, so (★3) implies uniform positive predecessor density (Corollary 4.4). Conditions (★3), (★2) and (★1) are all still unproved. They stand or fall together: (★3) carries the other two, so it is the only one whose truth remains to be established. Conjecture 2 is the source’s route into it and is not the only conceivable one.

Wirsching stated the weaker Conjecture 3 instead of the stronger $\varphi \sim \kappa\varphi_0$ he considers first. Theorem 10.2 shows why: the stronger statement fails by a mechanism with a certified, positive amplitude. Every phase $\theta \in [0, c)$ swept by H admits some sequence along which the ratio converges to $e^{H(\theta)}$: take $\tau_\ell := \Phi_0(\theta + \ell c)$, $z_\ell := e^{-\tau_\ell}$, so $w_0(\tau_\ell) = \theta + \ell c$ exactly, and apply Theorem 7.5, Proposition 8.2, and Proposition 9.1 as in the proof of Theorem 10.1. What is special about phase 0 is only that it is the one Wirsching’s own class $\tilde{A}_{\delta_5}$ happens to fix. That phase sits close to $w_{1011118}$, one of four points where H is printed in Proposition 6.5’s proof: combining that value with $H(0)$ gives $H(0) - H(w_{1011118}) = 5.25 \times 10^{-6}$, a floating-point computation (not itself a certified enclosure), against a certified oscillation of at least 4.18×10^{-4} . (Whether $w_{1011118}$ is where H attains its true minimum is not certified, per Proposition 6.5’s own caveat on the grid search.) We do not know whether the near-match with phase 0 is coincidental.

Remark 11.4 answers the other half of the question, why the weaker statement was enough. Wirsching’s proof does one thing with the constant, which is to cancel it across a factor of 3, and a factor of 3 is one period of H . His argument never sees the periodic correction at all.

Two numbers are worth putting beside Theorem 10.1. An evaluation of φ through depth $\ell = 500$, at 100-digit working precision and with zero truncation error at every point tested, was carried out before the theorem was proved. Extrapolating φ/φ_0 along the central sequence gave intercepts $\Lambda = -0.618860$ under a $\Lambda + b/\sqrt{\ell}$ model and $\Lambda = -0.599498$ under $\Lambda + b'/\ln^2 \ell$, the two fitting that range comparably, that is 0.53856 and 0.54909. The proved limit, in the same normalization, is $e^{H(0)} = 0.534122\dots$, so the two overshoot by 0.83% and 2.80% and the interval they span excludes it. The largest movement any check inside either model produced was 4.22×10^{-4} , from adding a further $1/\ell$ term, against a gap of 8.27×10^{-3} to the true value: a factor of 19.6. That shows the fitted intercepts are wrong over the range fitted. It does not show the expansions are: an approach $\Lambda_{\text{true}} + b\ell^{-1/2} + o(\ell^{-1/2})$ with a large lower-order term produces exactly this.

What remains is (★3), and establishing the antecedent leaves its difficulty exactly where it was. The asymmetry is the one recorded in §3: an implication whose hypothesis never sees a cannot on its own produce a bound uniform in a , and neither bridge the source offers from (★4) toward (★3) is uniform in growing resolution. Wirsching’s own analytic route of two years earlier, described in §2, ran into the same analytic-to-combinatorial gap.

The rate in Theorem 10.1 is not established beyond $o(1)$. The sharper Edgeworth correction of Remark 7.7, and a correspondingly sharper form of the envelope and Berg–Krüppel comparisons, would give an explicit polynomial rate throughout; neither theorem needs it.

Data Availability Statement

Every computation this paper reports is backed by a script in one repository, <https://github.com/faculdade/wirsching-conjectures-1-and-3>, organized as one folder per section of this paper and numbered as this paper numbers them, with a README per folder stating what its scripts verify, how to run them, and what to expect. Sections 1, 2, 3 and 5 carry no computation.

Two kinds of claim here are computer-assisted, and both are in the folder for §6: the enclosure of $\text{osc}(H)$ in Proposition 6.5 and the derivative bounds (10). These use Arb ball arithmetic through python-flint at a working precision stated at the top of the script, higher than the 250-bit precision quoted inline in Proposition 6.5’s proof, so they are an independent higher-precision reproduction of that certificate rather than a lower-precision approximation of it. Each prints its input balls and its final enclosure, so the printed run output is the certificate. The non-constancy of H is not among them: it is proved analytically from the zero-free theorem for ζ on $\text{Re } s = 1$, with no computation.

Everything else is exact integer or rational arithmetic, or high-precision floating arithmetic through mpmath. Where a script claims an inequality it asserts it and exits non-zero on failure. The evaluation of φ through depth $\ell = 500$ has zero truncation error at every point reported, the moments being exact rationals from the self-similarity $X \stackrel{d}{=} (2U + X)/3$; its working precision is 100 digits, so the printed decimals are a floating evaluation of an exact quantity.

Two earlier repositories preceded this one and remain where they are, with their DOIs valid: <https://github.com/faculdade/wirsching-conjecture3-proof>, archived at doi:10.5281/zenodo.21854549, commit f8248c3, for the standalone Conjecture 3 preprint; and <https://github.com/faculdade/collatz-wirsching-2003>, for the unsubmitted manuscript that carried Conjecture 1. Their scripts are carried into the repository above, renumbered to this paper’s sections. The first numbers its results as they were first published, where Theorem 10.1 is Theorem 1, Theorem 10.2 is Theorem 2, Corollary 10.3 is Corollary 3, Theorem 6.1 is Theorem 4, Proposition 6.3 is Proposition 6, Proposition 6.5 is Proposition 8, Theorem 7.5 is Theorem 13, Lemma 8.1 is Lemma 16, Proposition 8.2 is Proposition 17, Proposition 9.1 is Proposition 18 and Proposition 10.6 is Proposition 20; that mapping is repeated in the new repository’s own README.

Relation to earlier versions of this work

Wirsching’s Conjecture 1, §4 here, first circulated in an unsubmitted manuscript, together with material on Conjecture 2 not carried over. Conjecture 3, §§5 to 10 here, appeared as a preprint under the title *Wirsching’s Conjecture 3, and the periodic correction to Berg–Krüppel’s density asymptotic*. The present paper supersedes both. §11 is new here and appears in neither.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

The author conducted all research and wrote the manuscript. During the preparation of this work, the author used Claude (Anthropic) for textual review and translation. After using this tool, the author reviewed and edited the content as necessary and takes full responsibility for the content of the publication.

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